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A Smuggling approach to low focalisation

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Abstract. Drawing on cartographic assumptions that there exist discourse-related projections in the 'vP periphery'(Belletti 2001), we explore two types of postverbal focalisation in Lamnso and Limbum (Grassfields Bantu). The first type places an expletive pronoun and / or a copula before a contrastively focused constituent. The activation of the expletive and/or the copula in object focalisation induces freezing and minimality effects on subject and verb extraction. These effects are circumvented by evacuating the object(s) from the vP and by smuggling (Collins 2005) the remnant vP to Spec-AspP. This allows the verb to value its aspectual features and the subject to raise to its canonical preverbal position. Object focalisation in SVO(O)sequences requires evacuation of the arguments from the vP and remnant vP movement to Spec-AspP. Verbal copulas are taken as grammaticalised focus markers that lexicalise the focus head and attract focalised elements in Spec-FocP, while the expletive pronoun lexicalises a low subject projection. The second strategy involves verb-subject reversal and apparently in-situ object foci. It correlates with information and contrastive focus. Its derivation involves focus movement without necessarily applying smuggling.

Keywords. Cartography, copula, expletive, focus, Grassfields Bantu, smuggling

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1 Introduction

Grassfields Bantu languages are well known for their puzzling morphosyntax which displays intriguing properties such as complex verbal, nominal and tense systems, clause final particles, serial verbs, complex clause structure (e.g. Hyman 1979, Nkemnji 1995, Tamanji 1999, 2009, Fonkpu 2008, Nchare 2012, Ndamsah 2015) among many other properties.[1] One additional challenging morphosyntactic phenomenon that characterises these languages is focus marking. Beginning from Hyman (1979), Watters (1979), it has been observed that focus marking in many languages of this subgroup interacts closely with what has been dubbed in the literature as the Immediately After Verb position (IAV). By way of illustration, starting from the unmarked SVO(A) order in (1), it has been shown that narrow focus on the subject (2a) and the temporal adjunct (2b) in Aghem involves the placement of the focalised constituent immediately after the lexical verb (Hyman & Polinsky 2010: 206–207).

(1) tɨ́bvʉ́ tɨ̀bɨ̀ghà mɔ̂ zɨ̀ kɨ́bɛ́ ↓nɛ́
dogs two P1 eat fufu today
'The two dogs ate the fufu today.'

(2) a. à mɔ̀ zɨ̀ **tɨ́bvʉ́ tɨ̀bɨ̀ghà** bɛ́ ↓kɔ́ nɛ́
ES P1 eat dogs two fufu D.OBL today
'The TWO DOGS ate the fufu today.'
b. tɨ́bvʉ́ tɨ̀bɨ̀ghà mɔ̂ zɨ̀ **nɛ́** bɛ́ ↓kɔ́
dogs two P1 eat today fufu D.OBL
'The two dogs ate the fufu TODAY.'

As reported in Watters (1979: 141), noun roots in this language may loose their prefixes under some circumstances and gain suffixes under others. This certainly explains why the lexical item *kɨ́bɛ́* 'fufu' in (1) is truncated and realised as *bɛ́* in (2). Furthermore, one can observe the rise of the lexical item ↓*kɔ́* glossed as D.OBL in (2). For further details see (Watters 1979, Hyman & Polinksy 2010). The empirical coverage of a low focus position within the larger Grassfields subgroup has been enriched with a number of works such as Nkemnji (1995) for Nweh, Fonkpu (2008) for Lamnso, Tamanji (2009) for Bafut, Nchare (2012) for Shupamem, Keupdjio 2020, Zimmermann & Kouankem 2024 for Mə̀dʉ́mbɑ̀, Ndamsah (2015) for Limbum etc. For instance, Nchare (2012: 258-260) indicates that in Shupamem, the canonical SVO sentence in (3) conveys no particular focus reading on any constituent. Whether (3) can be appropriate in broad focus contexts or not is not mentioned by him.

(3) mɔ́n swò lɛ̀rwà tə̀ pàm
child put.PST book into bag
'The child put the book in the bag.'

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[1] The following abbreviations are used: AGR = agreement, ASP = aspect, CL= class, EXPL/ES = expletive, FOC = focus, FUT = future, FV= final vowel, ITER = iterative, NEG = negation, OBL= oblique, PREP = preposition, PST = past, PERF= perfective, PLUR= pluractional aspect, POSS= possessive, SG= first person singular, PL: plural, PROG = progressive, PRS = present, PRT= particle, REL = relative marker, SM = subject marker, TNS= tense, TOP = topic.

A narrow subject focus interpretation is obtained by subject reversal (4a) in a way that is analogous to Aghem (2a). Like in Aghem, when the focalised subject appears postverbally in Shupamem, the subject position is filled by an expletive pronoun. However, unlike in Aghem, non-subject focus in Shupamem can be realised postverbally when the target constituent is preceded by the focus marker *pò* whose tone may vary depending on the context (Nchare 2012). The following Shupamem examples are instances of subject focus (4a), direct object focus (4b) and adjunct focus (4c). We use the glossing system and translation as in the original work. As observed in (4b)–(4c), the focus marker linearly precedes the focalised constituent in what appears to be the canonical position of the latter.

(4) a. à swò **mɔ́n** lɛ́rwà tə̀ pàm mə̀
ES put child book into bag QM
'It is the child [who] put the book in the bag.'

b. mɔ́n swò **pò** **lɛ̀rwà** tə̀ pàm
child put FOC book into bag
'The child put the BOOK into the bag.'

c. mɔ́n swò lɛ̀rwà **pǒ** **tə̀** **pàm**
child put book FOC into bag
'The child put the book INTO THE BAG.'

This empirical data follows from a robust cross-linguistic generalisation about the locus of focus in the vicinity of the lexical verb. The existence of a focus position below the IP domain has been reported in other Bantu languages such as Kabiye (Collins & Essizewa 2007), Zulu (Zeller 2008, Halpert 2012), Makhuwa-Enahara (Van der Wal 2009), Basaá (Bassong 2014), other Bantu languages (Shlonsky 2024), in Spanish, Brazilian Portuguese and European Portuguese (Cépeda & Cyrino 2020), some oral dialects of Spanish (Bosque 1999, Sáez 2019), Italian (Belletti 2001, 2004, 2008), Hungarian (Kiss 1998), Malayalam (Jayaseelan 2001). Notwithstanding this empirical coverage, there is still a debate as to whether there is a dedicated focus position in the low IP field or not in the face of the structural distribution observed cross-linguistically. Putting aside the similarities between Aghem (2) and Shupamem (3) with respect to subject focus marking, a striking disparity emerges in non-subject focus. Whereas focalised subject and non-subject constituents are attracted immediately after the verb in Aghem (2), in Shupamem, a focalised non-subject constituent that is not the direct object cannot be attracted immediately after the verb (4c). More precisely, in the spirit of Watters (1979) and Hyman & Polinsky (2010), a sentence such as (5b) in Aghem is not expected to convey a narrow focus interpretation on the temporal adjunct ↓*nɛ́* 'today' in Aghem. Similarly, based on Nchare (2012), (6b) in Shupamem is ruled out because the focalised adjunct *tə̀ pàm* 'into the bag' occurs immediately after the verb, a strategy which is only possible in Aghem.

(5) a. When did the two dogs eat the fufu?

b. # tɨ́bvʉ́ tɨ̀bɨ̀ghà mɔ̂ zɨ̀ kɨ́bɛ́ ↓**nɛ́**
dogs two P1 eat fufu today
'The two dogs ate the fufu TODAY.'

(6) a. I heard that the child put the book **on the table**
b. * mɔ́n swò **pǒ** **tə̀** **pàm** lɛ̀rwà
child put FOC into bag book
Intended: 'The child put the book INTO THE BAG (not on the table).'

If all focused constituents were to occur immediately after the verb in Shupamem as is the case with Aghem, (6b) would be grammatical.

2 The subject matter

In this paper, we explore two instances of low (postverbal) focus strategies in the Grassfields Bantu languages Lamnso and Limbum. The first strategy concerns focalisation without any morphological focus marking. It is obtained verb–subject reversal as illustrated in (7) and (8) and in what apparently looks like 'in-situ' object focalisation in (9) and (10). SMALL CAPS in the translation indicate focus.

(7) a. Who gave Beri a fish?
b. ki fo **Buri** Beri sə̄ Lamnso.
PST2 give Buri Beri fish
'BURI gave Beri the fish.'

(8) a. Who is giving Nkunku a book?
b. tʃé fā **Nkehni** Nkunku ŋwàʔ Limbum.
PROG give Nkehni Nkunku book
'NKENI is giving Nkunku a book.'

(9) a. What did Buri kill?
b. Buri ʒuʒri **ʒó** Lamnso.
friend kill.PST1 snake
'Buri killed a SNAKE.'

(10) a. What did Nfor give to Nkunku?
b. Nfor à-mū-fā Nkunku **ŋwàʔ** Limbum
Nfor PST-PST2-give Nkunku book
'Nfor gave Nkunku a BOOK.'

The second strategy deals with morphological focus marking as depicted in (11) for subject focus in Lamnso and in (12) for direct object focus in Limbum. In Lamnso (11b), the focalised subject is preceded by the expletive pronoun *a* and the copula *dzə* 'be'. In Limbum (12b), the focused direct object *Nkunku* is preceded by the copula *bá* 'be' with no pre-copular expletive. The focalised constituents in (11b) and (12b) convey a contrastive interpretation.

(11) a. Who bought the shoes? Buri or Bih?
b. ki jūn *a* *dzə* **Buri** àlábá Lamnso
PST2 buy EXPL be Buri shoes
'BURI (not Bih) bought the shoes.'

(12) a. Nfor saw his friend yesterday.

	b.	(āji').	Nfor	à-mū	ye	*bá*	**Nkunku**	Limbum
		no	Nfor	PST-PST1	see	be	Nkunku	

'(No). Nfor saw NKUNKU (not his friend).'

Note that in both languages, there exists another focalisation strategy, it-*like* clefting, which is not addressed here.[2] We describe and analyse the two focus marking strategies presented in (7)–(12) in terms of syntax, semantics and pragmatics. We suggest a formal characterisation of both constructions drawing on cartographic assumptions that there are functional projections dedicated for focus and topic in the the vP periphery in line with (Belletti 2001, 2004) and related work. Central to our study is the view that the verbal copulas *dzə* and *bá* used in the focus constructions in (11) and (12) are grammaticalised focus markers that lexicalise the focus head in the syntax (see also Bosque 1999, Frascarelli 2010, 2011). The role of verbal copulas as functional items is to attract focalised constituents in the low focus area in the syntax. The presence of these copulas and the (c)overt expletives preceding them in the vicinity of focalised constituents leads us to postulate the existence of a low functional subject head in the vP periphery, in line with the cartography of subject positions in the clausal spine (Cardinaletti 2004; Shlonsky & Rizzi 2018; Roy & Shlonsky 2019). Contrary to previous studies on the cartography of subject positions, the function of the low subject in our study is merely to satisfy the formal requirement of a subject position akin to the satisfaction of the EPP property in mainstream minimalist analyses. As the expletive pronoun used in these focus constructions does not enter into a predication relation with the lexical verb, it is not associated with the interpretative properties of aboutness. Concerning clause internal topics in this study, they simply represent familiar or presupposed information in the background (Heim 1982, Roberts 2003, Frascarelli 2010, 2011) without any aboutness properties (e.g. Reinhart 1981, Rizzi 1997). The rest of the paper is organised as follows. Section 3 provides background information on the languages under discussion with special reference to their word order and agreement patterns (section 3.1), tense and aspect specification (section 3.1.2), morpho-syntactic and semantic evidence for verb movement (section 3.1.3) and the distribution of expletive pronouns and verbal copulas (section 3.1.4). Section 4 addresses the two focus strategies at issue with an accent on subject focus (section 4.1) and non-subject (object) focus (section 4.2). More

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[2] In both languages, clefts are introduced by a verbal copula. In Lamnso (i), the clefted subject *Buri* is preceded by the copula *dzə̀* 'be' and the expletive *a* is ruled out. In Limbum (ii), the focalised object is preceded by *á* the residual form of the copula *bá* 'be'. The difference between low focalisation in (11) and (12) and the cleft-*like* strategy in (i) and (ii) is that in Lamnso (i) clefting does not use the expletive pronoun while clefting in Limbum (ii) uses *á*, the reduced form of the copula *bá* 'be'. For more details on clefting (see Mbiydzenyuy Sala 1999, Fonkpu 2008, Moghaddam 2012 for Lamnso and Ndamsah 2015, Becker & Nformi 2016 and Becker, Driemel & Nformi 2019) for Limbum).

(i)	(*a)	*dzə*	**Buri**$_i$	**w-o**	**wu**$_i$	ki	fo-on	Beri	sə̄	Lamnso.
	EXPL	be	Buri	AGR-REL	he/she	PST	give-PRT	Beri	fish	

'It was Buri who gave Beri the fish.'

(ii)	(*b)*á*	**ŋwàʔ**	**tʃē**	Nkehni	à-mū	juu	Nkunku	Limbum.
	be	book	REL	Nkehni	PST-PST1	buy	Nkunku	

'It is a book that Nkunku is giving to Nkunku.'

specifically, section 4 is entirely concerned with the morpho-syntactic, semantic and pragmatic properties of subject and object focus. Section 5 deals with cartographic assumptions and the syntax of the two focus strategies under discussion. Section 6 concludes the study.

3 Preliminaries

Lamnso and Limbum are neighbouring Grassfields Bantu languages spoken in the North West region of Cameroon. Spoken in the Bui division by the Nso people, Lamnso is estimated to be spoken by 25, 000 speakers (Anderson 2015). According Mbiydzenyuy Sala (1999: 9), Lamnso has neighbouring languages such as Limbum in the north, Mbe and Tikari in the north east, Shupamem in the east, south east and south, Wushi and Papiakum in the south west, Kuo (Oku) and Noone in the northwest. From the point of view of genetic classification, Lewis et al. (2015) classify Lamnso as a Niger-Congo, Atlantic-Congo, Volta-Congo, Benue-Congo, Bantoid, Southern, Narrow Grassfields, Ring, East language. Some linguistics works on Lamnso include Grebe (1982, 1984), Mbiydzenyuy Sala (1999), Fonkpu (2008), Moghaddam (2012), Anderson (2015). Limbum is spoken by the Mbum people in the Nkambe and Ndu subdivisions in the Donga Mantung division. It is coded 903 by Dieu & Renaud (1983) and is reported to have three intercomprehensible dialects, namely the central, the northern and southern dialects (Ndamsah 2015). The number of speakers was recently estimated around 130,000 (Eberhard et al. 2019). Limbum belongs to the Northern subgroup of the Eastern Grassfields field Bantu. Broadly speaking, recent classification of Limbum indicates that it is a Niger-Congo, Benue-Congo, Bantoid, Bantu, Eastern Grassfields Bantu language (Ndamsah 2015). Some previous research on Limbum linguistics include Fiore (1987), Nforgwei (1991, 2007), Cheffy (1992), Mpoche (1993), Fransen (1995), Ndamsah (1998, 2015, 2021), Becker and Nformi (2016), Becker, Driemel & Nformi (2019), Nformi (2019) and Hein (2021).

3.1 Grammatical background

This section provides some grammatical properties in both languages in order to familiarise the reader with their internal structure. Lamnso and Limbum are characterised by tone marking distinction, complex verbal morphology and noun class systems. Like many Bantu languages, each language distinguishes between three simple tones, namely a low [̀], a high [́] and a mid [̄] tone. Complex tones include a rising tone [̌] and a falling one [̂]. Tone has a distinctive function in both languages (e.g. Fransen 1995, Fonkpu 2008, Ndamsah 2015).

3.1.1 Morphological agreement

Agreement between the head noun and its dependents is generally encoded morphologically for some noun classes as illustrated in (13) for Lamnso and (14) for Limbum (Ndamsah 2015: 52–53). The dependents agree in noun class with the head within the noun phrase. Whereas some noun classes are marked with overt prefixes, others display no overt prefix morphology. In the following examples, the zero (ø) symbol represents the absence of morphological marking. Cardinal numbers on the head nouns and their dependents indicate the noun class.

(13)	a.	**shi**-nən	**sh**-ém	vs.	**me**-nən	**m**-ém
		5-bird	5-poss.1SG		6-birds	6-POSS.1SG
		'My bird'			'My birds.'	
	b.	**ki**- tʃĩ	**ki**-mo'on	vs.	**vi**-tʃĩ	**vi**-kwee
		7-tree	7-one		8-trees	8-four
		'One tree.'			'Four trees.'	

(14)	a.	**j**-à	**ɵ**-síŋ	vs.	**w**-à	**p**-síŋ
		1-POSS.SG	1-bird		2-POSS.1SG	2-birds
		'My bird.'			'My birds.'	
	b.	**l**-á	**r̄**-wɛ̄	vs.	**m**-á	**m**-wɛ̄
		5-POSS.1SG	5-cat		6-POSS.1SG	6-cats
		'My cat.'			'My cats.'	

3.1.2 Tense and aspect specification and the verbal complex

Like in many Bantu languages, the verbal complex in the two languages delineates an array of identifiable and distinct morphemes that encode specific morpho-syntactic and semantic functions. However, unlike in many noun class Bantu languages, subject verb agreement in many Grassfields Bantu languages is not encoded consistently. Agreement between the subject and the verb is restricted to some noun classes based on their semantic properties (e.g. Mbiydzenyuy Sala 1999 and Fonkpu 2008 for Lamnso and Ndamsah 2015 for Limbum). For instance, proper names, human and kinship nouns do not have corresponding subject markers in canonical SVO sentences. In such cases, null subjects are not licenced as shown in Lamnso (15a)–(15b).

(15)	a.	**Chin**	yíí	fó	Bih	sə̄	lān	Lamnso
		Chin	FUT	give	Bih	fish	today	
		'Chin gave Bih the fish today.'						
	b.	* yíí	fó	Bih	sə̄	lān		
		FUT	give	Bih	fish	today		

In (15), a null subject is disallowed in (15b) because the subject is a proper name. As a result, no subject marker is available to recover the properties of the missing subject. Conversely, in (16b) the subject can be omitted without any ungrammaticality because the missing subject is recoverable from the morphology of the subject marker *ki*.

(16)	a.	**Kimbáŋ**	**kí**-yíí-fó	kibán	í	Bih	Lamnso
		whiteman	SM-FUT-give	fufu	PREP	Bih	
		'The white man will give fufu to Bih today.'					

	b.	**kí**	yíí	fó	kibán	í	Bih
		SM	FUT	give	fufu	PREP	Bih
		'He will give fufu to Bih today.'					

As shown in (16a)–(16b), the canonical subject can be dropped in the presence of a subject marker (SM). Null subjects are licensed only for some noun classes that are neither proper names nor kinship terms. Such nouns trigger morphological agreement on the verb and null subjects are licensed when the subject is salient or recoverbale from the discourse, in accordance with Taraldsen's (1980) generalisation (see also Rizzi 1986, Adams 1987). Similar results are obtained in Limbum in (17) and (18).

(17) a. Nkunku tʃē tʃāŋ-i — Limbum
Nkunku PROG run-FV
'Nkunku is running.'
b. * tʃē tʃāŋ-i
PROG run-FV

(18) a. **p-síŋ** **ví**-bé-lò-jē bā: — Limbum
CL-birds SM-FUT-FUT1-eat fufu
'The birds will eat the fufu.'
b. **ví**-bé-lò-jē bā:
SM-FUT-FUT1-eat fufu
'They will eat the fufu.'

No subject marker is available between the subject and the verb in (17a) because the subject is a proper name. Thus, dropping the subject leads to illicitness (17b). Conversely, in (18b) where the subject is neither a proper name nor a kinship term, a null subject is allowed. Like in many noun class Bantu languages, subject verb agreement is local and realised overtly by means of a subject marker. As mentioned earlier, morphological subject–verb agreement in these two languages is restricted to contexts in which the lexical subject is neither a proper name nor a kinship term.

The examples in (a) in (16) and (18) indicate that these languages display agglutinative morphemes that form the verbal complex. The different functional morphemes that make up the verbal complex encode different functions such as agreement, tense and aspect specification. Sometimes, tense and aspect morphemes have no morphological exponent. We do not intend to provide an exhaustive discussion on the tense and aspect systems here. However, it is important to highlight the fact that these languages are also characterised by a rich and complex tense system. Unlike the present tense which is morphologically unmarked in both languages, each language makes use of distinct morphemes to encode the past and future tenses as in (19) for Lamnso and (20) for Limbum respectively.

(19) a. Beri *fo* Buri ki-bam ke-ʒuŋ — Lamnso
Beri give.PRS Buri 7-bag 7-nice
'Beri gives Buri a nice bag.'
b. Wan **ki** jí kingom
child PST1 eat banana
'The child ate a banana (today).'
c. Limnyuy **ghán** *bóm* láv
Limnyuy FUT3 build house
'Limnyuy will build a house (at some point in the future).'

(20) a. Nfor *fā* ŋkār jì ŋwaʔ — Limbum
Nfor give.PRS friends POSS.3PL book
'Nfor gives his friends the book.'

b. Nkunku **à** **mū** *tʃɔ̄ʔ* mŋkū à ŋgàptʉ̄ʔ
Nkunku PST PST2 remove beans PREP morning
'Nkunku harvested the beans in the morning (a week or a month ago).'

c. Málāʔ **bé** **fū** **sā** gū
Malah FUT FUT1 split wood
'Malah will split the wood (today).'

Note in passing that these languages are characterised by a graded tense system. They distinguish between three types of past and three types of future tenses depending on the event time. Compared to Lamnso, Limbum has a general past tense marker *à* that always associates with past tense forms. Similarly, the general future tense marker *bé* always combines with future tense morphemes (Ndamsah 2015). Agreement, tense, aspect and negation can interact in the same clause as shown in (21) for Lamnso and (22) for Limbum.

(21) a. menən **me-jo'-oó-si-***jí* vingom S…AGR-NEG-TNS-ASP-V…O
6birds 6SM-NEG-PST3-PROG-eat 8bananas
'The birds were not eating bananas (a long time ago).'

b. menən **me-ki-***jí***-né** vingom S…AGR-TENS-V-ASP…O
6birds 6SM-PST1-eat-PERF 8bananas
'The birds ate bananas (today).'

(22) a. Nfor **tʃē** *tū*-**ʃī** Nkunku gɔ̄r S…ASP-V-ASP…O
Nfor PROG send-PLUR Nkunku much
'Nfor was sending Nkunku many times.'

b. **p-síŋ** **ví-bé-lò-***jē***-ŋgér**-ī bā: **kāʔ** S...AGR-TNS-V-ASP-FV-..O..NEG
CL-birds SM-FUT-FUT1-eat-ITER fufu NEG
'The birds will eat the fufu repeatedly.'

In (21a), the verb *jí* 'eat' is preceded from left to right by the subject–verb agreement morpheme, negation, tense and the progressive aspect morphemes. In (21b), the verb occurs between the perfective aspect *-né* on its right and agreement, negation and tense on its left. In (22a), the verb *tū* 'send' is sandwiched between the progressive and the pluractional aspect markers. In (22b), the verb *jē* 'eat' occurs between agreement and tense on the left, and the iterative aspect on the right. In comparison with Lamnso (21a) where sentential negation is preverbal, in Limbum negation is clause final (22b). As part of the general characteristics of the grammar of these languages, we dedicate our attention to verb movement as a salient feature of the focus constructions under investigation.

3.1.3 Evidence for verb movement in Lamnso and Limbum

In this section, we provide two arguments in favour of verb movement in both languages. We address the relative order between the verb and tense and aspect. Then, we zoom in on the placement of focus-sensitive particles.

To begin with, the sentences in (21) and (22) repeated as (23) and (24) for convenience reveal a distributional asymmetry between tense and aspect with respect to the position of the verb. Tense is marked by prefixation in each language while aspect can be marked either through prefixation (23a) or suffixation (23b) for Lamnso.[3] In (23a), the verb *jí* 'eat' is preceded by the progressive marker *si* whereas it is followed by the perfective morpheme *né* in (23b). In Limbum (24), aspect is marked by prefixation and suffixation in (24a). The verb *tū* 'send' is sandwiched between the progressive and the pluractional aspect morphemes. In (24b) the verb *jē* 'eat' precedes the iterative aspect suffix *ŋgér* which precedes the final vowel *ī* in turn.

(23)	a.	menən	**me-jo'-oó-si-***jí*	vingom		S…AGR-NEG-TNS-ASP-V…O
		6birds	6SM-NEG-PST3-PROG-eat	8bananas		
		'The birds were not eating bananas (a long time ago).'				
	b.	menən	**me-ki-***jí***-né**	vingom		S…AGR-TENS-V-ASP…O
		6birds	6SM-PST1-eat-PERF	8bananas		
		'The birds ate bananas (today).'				

(24)	a.	Nfor	**tʃē**	*tū***-ʃī**	Nkunku	gɔ̄r	S…ASP-V-ASP…O
		Nfor	PROG	send-PLUR	Nkunku	much	
		'Nfor was sending Nkunku many times.'					
	b.	**p-síŋ**	**ví-bé-lò-***jē***-ŋgér-**ī	bā:	**kāʔ**		S...AGR-TNS-V-ASP-FV-..O..NEG
		CL-birds	SM-FUT-FUT1-eat-ITER	fufu	NEG		
		'The birds will not eat the fufu repeatedly.'					

When tense and aspect interact in the same clause as in (23) and (24b), tense always precedes aspect. The order of the verb and the aspectual morphemes in the two languages suggests that the verb is able to move out of the vP to pick up the [Asp(ect)] features (Pollock 1989, Aboh & Dyakonova 2009, Kandybowicz & Torrence 2021). We entertain the idea that even in cases like (24a) where tense has no morphological realisation, it is present in the syntax though silent at PF. This also holds for (25) and (26) where tense and aspect are covert at PF.

(25)	Beri	*fo*	Buri	ki-bam	ke-ʒuŋ
	Beri	give.PRS	Buri	7-bag	7-nice
	'Beri gives Buri a nice bag.'				

(26)	Nfor	*fā*	ŋkār	jì	ŋwaʔ
	Nfor	give.PRS	friends	POSS.3PL	book
	'Nfor gives his friends the book.'				

That the verb moves out of the vP is also supported by the distribution of focus-sensitive operators such as *tʃá* 'only' in Lamnso and *fɔ́ŋ* 'also' in Limbum. In (27a) and (28a), when the focus operator follows the verb, one obtains a wide scope on the entire vP. In Lamnso (27b), the exclusive operator *tʃá* 'only' has narrow scope only on the direct object following it. Interestingly, in Limbum (28b), where the additive operator *fɔ́ŋ* 'also' is clause final the operator does not only have narrow scope on the direct object preceding it, but it also has wide scope on the whole vP.

[3] As mentioned earlier, the present tense in both languages is not morphologically realised. An analysis along the lines of verb movement would assume that in the present tense, the lexical verb raises and adjoins to a silent tense marker.

(27) a. Bih ki fo **tʃá** Limnyuy ŋwaʔ Lamnso Only > vP
Bih PST2 give only Limnyuy book
'Bih only GAVE LIMNYUY A BOOK.'
b. Bih ki fo Limnyuy **tʃá** ŋwaʔ Only > DP
Bih PST2 give Limnyuy only book
'Bih gave Limnyuy only A BOOK.'

(28) a. jà tâ dùŋshī **fɔ́ŋ** Nfor ndāp Limbum Also > vP
POSS.1G father show.PRS also Nfor house
'My father also SHOWS NFOR THE HOUSE.'
b. jà tâ dùŋshī Nfor ndāp **fɔ́ŋ** Also > vP or Also > $DP_{a\ house}$
POSS.1G father show.PRS Nfor house also
'My father showed Nfor also the HOUSE.'
'My father also SHOWED NFOR THE HOUSE.'

These different readings are possible if we assume that in (27a) and (28a), the focus operator is either left-adjoined to the vP (29a) or merged in the specifier position of some functional projection dedicated to adverbs (29b) in the low IP spine. The head of this functional projection c-commands vP in the spirit of Cinque (1999)'s adverb hierarchy.

(29) a. …$[_{AspP}[_{Asp}$ **V+Asp** $[_{vP}$ (*only*/*also*) $[_{vP}$ $[t_v$ $[_{VP}[_V$ t_V]]]] vP-adjoined adverbs
b. …$[_{AspP}[_{Asp}$ **V+Asp** $[_{FP}$ (*only*/*also*) $[_F$ t_v $[_{vP}$ $[t_v$ $[_{VP}[_V$ t_V]]]] Specifier-based adverbs

Whatever the case, the verb has to move across the focus operator on its way to the inflectional domain. This means that the focus operator is merged in a position where it c-commands its focus prior to the movement of the latter across the focus operator. If this is true, the scope relations take place prior to verb movement to the inflectional domain. With this in mind, the narrow scope reading on the direct object obtained in (27b) and (28b) is accounted if we assume that the focus operator is merged in a c-commanding position inside the DP so much so that scope relations take place prior to N movement to D or NP to Spec-DP across the focus operator merged in a functional phrase position inside the DP. In concrete terms, if the focus operator in (27b) is adjoined to NP or to some other functional projection inside the DP, the narrow scope reading in Lamnso is easily obtained since the operator is higher than its focus as briefly depicted in (30a). Conversely, in Limbum (28b) we have to assume that the head noun or the NP raises pass the focus operator as represented in (30b) and (30c).

(30) a. $[_{DP}$ **(only/also)**$[_{DP}$ $[_D$ $[_{NP}$ **(only/also)** $[_{NP}$ $[_N$]] Only > NP
b. $[_{DP}$ $[_{N+D}$ $[_{NP}$ **(only/also)** $[_{NP}$ [<N>]] Also > NP
c. $[_{DP\ NP}$ $[_{NP}$ **(only/also)** [<NP>]] Also > NP

Based on this, the wide scope reading of the clause final additive operator *fɔ́ŋ* 'also' over the vP in (28b) is understood if we posit that the entire vP moves across the focus operator to some functional projection above the position hosting the additive focus particle in the low functional spine above the vP. Considering the distribution and interpretation of focus operators as well as the interaction between the verb and the aspect/tense morphemes, we are led to contend that verb movement is available in Lamnso and Limbum. The verb does not remain inside the vP layer. It has to raise to the inflectional domain to value its aspect/tense features.

3.1.4 On expletive pronouns and verbal copulas

Lamnso and Limbum form copula clauses with the verbal copulas *dzə̀* and *jū* respectively. They correspond to the English *BE*. Unlike the Lamnso *dzə̀* which is morphologically invariable, the Limbum *jū* has suppletive forms and is sensitive to tense specification. This illustrated in the canonical copular structures in (31) for Lamnso and (32) for Limbum.

(31) a. Bih wun Limnyuy **dzə** ŋkar sem — Lamnso
Bih and Limnyuy be.PRS friends POSS.1SG
'Bih and Limnyuy are my friends.'

b. Bih wun Limnyuy jo' *laa* **dzə** ŋkar sem
Bih and Limnyuy NEG PST be friends POSS.1SG
'Bih and Limnyuy were not my friends

c. Bih *jíi* **dzə** ŋkar ʒem
Bih FUT be friends POSS.1SG
'Bih will be my friend.'

(32) a. Malah **jū** jà tâ — Limbum
Malah be.PRS POSS.1SG father
'Malah is my father.'

b. Malah *à* *m̀* **bā** jà tâ
Malah PST PST3 be POSS.1SG father
'Malah was my father.'

c. Malah *bé* **bā** jà tâ
Malah FUT be POSS.1SG father
'Malah will be my father.'

Recall that the present tense has no overt morphology in the two languages unlike the past and future. As discussed in section 2 and as it will be discussed extensively in section 4, these copulas are also used for focusing. The two languages have expletive pronouns as can be seen in (33) and (34). Lamnso uses the expletive *ki* or *a* (33) and Limbum uses *é* (34). The use of *a* in expletive with raising verbs like *seem, appear* etc. varies among Lamnso speakers as indicated by the % symbol.[4]

(33) a. **ki** / %**a** din ʒí wan ki ʒí-kɨr-ani — Lamnso
EXPL EXPL show.PRS that child PST2 eat-IMPF-PRT
'It appears that the child has eaten.'

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[4] Though speakers find *ki* as the appropriate expletive unambiguously in contexts such as (33), some are hesitant with respect to the use of the expletive *a* in the same contexts. Fonkpu (2007) indicates that the use of *a* is appropriate in expletive constructions such as (i).

(i) **a** **dzə̀** ki-nyo kee juŋ ki foo-du fo shikur
EXPL be CL-thing CL-AGR good AGR INF-go PREP school
'It's a good thing to go to school.' Adapted from Fonkpu (2007: 204).

b.	**ki** /	%**a**	(*dzə̀)	bɔŋ	fo-kɔŋ	woni
	EXPL	EXPL	be.PRS	good	INF-love	children

‘It is good to love children.’

c.	**ki**	/ %**a**	kiʔ	moo	ʒí	Bih	méé-ani
	EXPL	EXPL	seem.PRS	as if	that	Bih	arrive.PST-PERF

‘It seems that Bih arrived.’

(34)	a.	**é**	fjésé	àmù	ŋkar	jà	kɔŋ	Nfor	Limbum
		EXPL	appear.PRS	like	friend	POSS.1SG	love.PRS	Nfor	

‘It appears that my friend loves Nfor.’

b.	**é**	m̀	bā	jɛ́nì	àr-dēʔ	wèsò
	EXPL	PST3	be	well	INF-talk	you

‘It was nice to talk with you.’

c.	**é**	bɔ̀ŋ	àr-ʃɛ́p	bwāʔbee	kāʔ
	EXPL	good	INF-insult	children	neg

‘It is not good to insult the children.’

Recall that none of the expletives *ki* in Lamnso (33) and *é* in Limbum (34) is used in focus constructions. At this point, we have laid the foundations for our discussion by providing ingredients for a better understanding of the subject matter of our study. Section 4 below opens the discussion about the phenomenon under study.

4 Focus marking strategies

This section focuses on the two focus strategies highlighted in section 2, namely postverbal focalisation with no morphological marking and postverbal focalisation with morphological marking by means of a verbal copula with and without an expletive pronoun.

4.1 Subject focus

Many Grassfields Bantu languages such as Nweh (Nkemnji 1995), Bafut (Tamanji 2009), Shupamem (Nchare 2012), Awing (Fominyam & Šimík 2017) etc. mark subject focus in two different positions. Lamnso and Limbum are no exception to this rule. We restrict our attention to postverbal subject focus.

4.1.1 Subject focus: New and contrastive information

Subject focus can be realised in the same structural position through two distinct strategies. Each strategy conveys specific semantic/pragmatic effects. The first strategy deals with verb subject reversal as used in the question-answer pairs in Lamnso (35) and Limbum (36).

(35) a. Who gave Beri this book?

b.	ki	fo	**Bih**	Beri	(***Bih**)	ŋwa	vāj	(***Bih**)	Lamnso
	PST1	give	Bih	Beri	Bih	book	this	Bih	

‘BIH gave Beri this book.’

c. #Bih ki fo Beri ŋwa vāj
Bih PST1 give Beri book this
'Bih gave Beri this book today.'

(36) a. Who showed Nkunku the children?
b. à m̀ dùŋshī **Nfor** Nkunku (***Nfor**) bwaʔbee (***Nfor**) Limbum
PST PST3 show Nfor Nkunku Nfor children Nfor
'NFOR showed Nkunku the children.'
c. #Nfor à m̀ dùŋshī Nkunku bwaʔbee
Nfor PST PST3 show Nkunku children
'Nfor showed Nkunku the children.'

As indicated in the answers in (c), preverbal subjects are pragmatically infelicitous in a context that appeals to the identification of the subject. The focalised subject cannot be preceded by any element except for the verb. In (35) and (36), the postverbal subject is the most salient part of the sentence and represents new or non-presupposed information in the discourse (Jackendoff 1972, Kiss 1998). Verb–subject inversion as a focus strategy is not restricted to the Grassfields Bantu subgroup. It is well known in the literature and has been reported extensively across eastern and southern Bantu languages (e.g. Zeller 2008, Halpert 2012, 2015, Riedel 2009, Van der Wal 2009.) and across Romance (e.g. Zubizarreta 1998, Belletti 2001, 2004, Cruschina 2012, 2022). Postverbal subject focus does not necessarily represent new information in the discourse. It can also encode contrast as shown in (37) for Lamnso and (38) for Limbum.

(37) a. **Limnyuy** ki jen Bih i kwa Lamnso
Limnyuy PST2 see Bih PREP bush
'Limnyuy saw Bih in the bush.'
b. àjà. ki jen **Beri** Bih / wun
no PST2 see Beri Bih her
'No, BERI (not Limnyuy) saw Bih/her.'
c. # àjà. **Beri** ki jen Bih / wun
no Beri PST2 see Bih her
'No, Beri (not Limnyuy) saw Bih/her.'

(38) a. Nfor à mū la inɛ **ŋkar ji** à mū dû Limbum
Nfor PST PST2 say that friend POSS.1SG PST PST2 go
'Nfor said that his friend left.'
b. àji'. à mū du **ŋgwa ji**
no PST PST go wife his
'No. HIS WIFE (not his fiend) left.'
c. # àji'. **ŋgwa ji** à mū dû
no wife his PST PST go
'No. His wife (not his friend) left.'

In (37) and (38) the focalised subject is postverbal as indicated in the (b)'s answers. Placing the subject in its canonical/unmarked position leads to unacceptability as shown by the infelicitous replies in (c). In (37) and (38), the focalised subjects contrast salient alternatives (Rooth 1992, Krifka 2008) activated in the previous discourse. In the spirit of (E. Kiss 1998), these focalised subjects encode identificational focus. In each case, the focused subject represents a subset of the set of contextually salient alternatives for which the predicate holds.

Shortly, subject focus in Lamnso and Limbum can be expressed through verb–subject reversal and is incompatible with the canonical SVO order. Based on the question-answer congurence as well as contextually given alternatives in the discourse, it follows that verb–subject reversal in both languages is compatible with new and contrastive information. The fact that subject focus in these languages is always marked follows from two general assumptions. First of all, the reversal strategy has often been reported to be a property of null-subject languages in which the position of the subject can be filled by a null pro. This is true of Romance (Gutiérrez-Bravo 2008, Belletti 2001, 2004, Cruschina 2022), some Eastern Bantu (Riedel 2009, Van der Wal 2012) and Southern Bantu (Zeller 2008, Halpert 2012, 2015). This is also true in Grassfields Bantu languages though from a different perspective. It was shown in section 3 that null subjects are restricted to some noun classes in Lamnso and Limbum. However, subject reversal is incompatible with subject–verb agreement. In other words, subject markers are the only elements that license null subjects in canonical SVO sentences. This is illustrated in the (b)'s examples in Lamnso (39) and Limbum (40). In verb–subject reversal where the subject is focused, subject-verb agreement is ruled out as shown in the (c)'answers.

(39) a. **menən** **me-**jo'-oó-si-jí vingom — Canonical SVO
6birds 6SM-NEG-PST3-PROG-eat 8bananas
'The birds were not eating the bananas.'

b. **me-**jo'-oó-si-jí vingom — Null subject
6SM-NEG-PST3-PROG-eat 8bananas
'They were not eating the bananas.'

c. (***me**)-jo'-oó-si-jí **menən** vingom — Subject reversal
6SM-NEG-PST3-PROG-eat 6birds 8bananas
'The BIRDS were not eating the bananas.'

(40) a. **p-síŋ** **ví**-bé-lò-jē bā: — Canonical SVO
CL-birds SM-FUT-FUT1-eat fufu
'The birds will eat the fufu.'

b. **ví**-bé-lò-jē bā: — Null subject
SM-FUT-FUT1-eat fufu
'They will eat the fufu.'

c. (***ví**)-bé -lò-jē **p-síŋ** bā: — Subject reversal
SM-FUT-FUT1-eat CL-birds fufu
'The BIRDS will eat the fufu.'

The examples in (35)–(40) show that subject inversion is compatible with focus but is incompatible with subject–verb agreement. We simply consider that in subject reversal contexts, the preverbal position is occupied by a nonreferential null *pro* without any visible subject-verb agreement (see also Guasti & Rizzi 2002 on the parametric variation agreement). What these Grassfields Bantu data suggest is that in these languages, *Agree* and *Move* are not two independent operations as in mainstream minimalist analyses (Chomsky 1995). In these languages and as reported in some previous work across Bantu, *Agree* and *Move* operate in tandem (Baker 2003, Collins 2004, Carstens 2005), though opposite results are obtained from some eastern Bantu (e.g. Van der Wal (2012). The patterns in (39) and (40) reveal that the agreement trigger, namely the subject marker should end up in a local Spec-Head configuration with the subject if we assume that the subject starts low within the vP (Koopman & Sportiche 1991). The sentences in (41b) and (42b) are completely degraded because the null subject has no licensor, namely a subject marker and the sentence lacks a postverbal subject.

(41) a. **Beri** jen wun
Beri see.PST her
'Beri saw her.'
b. *ki jen wun
PST2 see her

(42) a. **ŋgwa ji** à mū dû
wife POSS.1SG PST PST2 go
'His wife left.'
b. *à mū dû
PST PST2 go

This empirical evidence reveals that subject reversal in focalisation is not necessarily a property of null subject languages because it can occur even in cases where null subjects are unavailable in canonical SVO sentences. Referential null subjects in these languages are licensed only in canonical SVO structures like in (39b) and (40b) while expletive null subjects are allowed only in VS structures with no preverbal subject–verb agreement like in (39c) and (40c). Another assumption about the obligatory encoding of subject focus cross-linguistically usually follows from a generalisation that preverbal subjects have topic-*like* properties (Rizzi 2005). As such, subject focus marking has often been attributed to an interpretative conflict between subjects and topics (Givón 1967, Morimoto 2000, Zeller 2008, Cruschina 2022). However, opposing views do exist (e.g. Zerbian (2006), Van der Wal (2009), Halpert (2012), Cheng & Downing (2014)). From the perspective of the interpretative conflict between subjects and topics, the lexical subject has to be 'detopicalised' through focus marking. We refrain ourselves from addressing this issue here.[5]

4.1.2 Strictly contrastive subject focus

In this section, we address a specific case of subject focus marking which is always interpreted exhaustively in many Grassfields Bantu languages. In the VS structure in Lamnso (43b), the focalised subject *Chin* is preceded by the expletive *a* and the copula *dzə̀* 'be'. The subject is interpreted contrastively (see also Fominyam & Simik 2017, Zimmermann & Kouankem 2024 for similar results in the Grassfields Bantu Awing and Mə̀dʉ́mbɑ̀ respectively).

[5] The impossibility of licensing focalised subjects in the preverbal position is attributed to criterial freezing (cf. Bassong, Ossoko & Rizzi forthcoming). Briefly stated, the fact that focalised subjects cannot occur in the structural subject position in many African languages is linked to the fact that subject movement to the subject position triggers freezing effects on the subject, in line with the criterial approach to subject positions (Rizzi 2015, Shlonsky & Rizzi 2018). This prevents it from moving further in the focus domain in the left periphery. As Lamnso and Limbum do not have a structural focus phrase in the left periphery, they rather exploit the low focus field through verb–subject reversal or clefting to satisfy the focus requirements while a null expletive pronoun satisfies the subject-criterion preverbally.

(43) a.

Buri	jɔŋ	ʒí	**Beri**	ki	yen-a	
Buri	say.PRS	that	3.SG	PST	see-PRT	Limnyuy

‘Buri says that Beri saw Limnyuy.’

b.

ājà.	ki	yen	**a**	**dzə**	**Chin**	Limnyuy	/	wun
no	PST	see	EXPL	be	Chin	Limnyuy		3SG

‘No. CHIN (not Beri) saw Limnyuy / him.’

Similarly, in Limbum (44b), the postverbal subject *Nkunku* is preceded by the copula *bá* and is interpreted contrastively.

(44) a.

Nfor	tʃē	kwa’shi	inɛ	**Malah**	à	mū	ju	rkar
Nfor	PROG	think	that	Malah	PST	PST2	buy	car

‘Nfor thinks that Malah bought a car.’

b.

à	mū	ju	**bá**	**Nkunku**	jī
PST	PST2	buy	be	Nkunku	it

‘No, NKUNKU (not Malah) bought it.’

That a postverbal subject marked by the copula is interpreted only contrastively is supported by the following question-answer pairs requiring new information about the subject. Thus, the use of the copula is inappropriate in information focus as illustrated in (45) and (46).

(45) a. Who saw Limnyuy this morning?

b.

ki	yen	(#a	dzə)	**Chih**	wun
PST	see	EXPL	be	Chin	3SG

‘CHIH saw her/him.’

(46) a. Who bought a car?

b.

à	mū	ju	(#bá)	**Nkunku**	jī
PST	PST2	buy	be	Nkunku	it

‘NKUNKU bought it.’

In partial conclusion, we have examined two subject focus marking strategies in Lamnso and Limbum. The first deals with subject reversal whereby the focalised subject immediately follows the lexical verb without any morphological encoding on the inverted subject. This strategy can be used in both languages for information and contrastive focus under appropriate discourse conditions. The second strategy consists in placing the postverbal subject after a verbal copula. In Lamnso the copula is also accompagnied by an expletive pronoun while in Limbum only the copula shows up before the focalised subject. Unlike the first focus strategy, the second one is used only for contrastive focus in both languages.

4.2 Non-subject focus

This section discusses non-subject focus with a special attention to objects. No mention is made of verb and adjunct focus in this paper. For further details, see Ndamsah (2015), Becker &

Nformi (2016), Becker, Driemel & Nformi (2019) on Limbum and Mbiydzenyuy Sala (1999), Fonkpu (2008) on Lamnso. Our study is limited to two object focusing strategies. [6]

4.2.1 Postverbal object focus with copula marking

Like postverbal subject focus, postverbal object focus marking with a copula is always contrastive as indicated in Lamnso (47) and Limbum (48).

(47) a. Beri ki fo wán **àlábá**
Beri PST1 give child shoes
'Beri gave the shoes to the child.'
b. ājà. wu ki fo wún **a dzə mbam**
no 3SG PST1 give 3SG EXPL be money
'No, he gave him/her the MONEY (not the shoes).'

(48) a. Nkunku à mū dùŋshi Nfor **ɲɔ̄**
Nkunku PST PST2 show Nfor snake
'Nkunku showed Nfor a snake.'
b. āji' é à mū dùŋshi jɛ̄ **bá ŋgwē**
no 3SG PST PST2 show 3SG be dog
'No. He showed him a DOG (not a snake).'

The unacceptability of (49b) and (50b) indicates that postverbal objects marked with the copula are inappropriately interpreted in information focus situations. The (b) answers are appropriate only when the speaker intends to express contrast.

(49) a. What did Beri give to Chin?
b. Wu ki fo wún (#a dzə**) mbam**
3SG PST1 give 3SG EXPL be money
'He gave him/her the MONEY.'
(50) a. What did Nkunku show to Nfor?
b. é à mū dùŋshi jɛ̄ (#**bá**) **ŋgwē**
3SG PST PST2 show 3SG be dog
'He showed him a DOG.'

4.2.2 Object placement and focus marking with(out) the copula

In many languages, information structure interacts with word order (Cépeda & Cyrino 2020, Lacerda 2020, Shlonsky 2024). Lamnso and Limbum are two cases in point. The 'unmarked' order in 'out-of-the-blue' utterances with double constructions is SV.IO.DO.A(djunct). This is determined on the basis of the elicitation of 'all-new' or 'out-of-the-blue' contexts in (51) for Lamnso and (52) for Limbum.

[6] Verb focus in the two languages is encoded by doubling the verb. The doubled verb usually takes an infinitive form which can be clause initial or final. Focalisation of adjuncts behaves on a par with object focalisation.

(51) a. koj ka / dzə ka Lamnso
happen.PST1 what be.PRS what
'What happened?' / What's it?
b. Beri ki fo baá wom mbam (#baá wom)
Beri PST1 give father POSS.1SG money father POSS.1SG
'Beri gave the money to my father.'

(52) a . à mū kɔ̀né kɛ́: / á kɛ́: tʃé jí à mū kɔ́né Limbum
PST PST2 happen what be what REL 3SG PST PST2 happen
'What happened?' /what is it that happened?
b. Nkunku à mū dùŋshī Nfor ŋkār jà (#Nfor)
Nkunku PST PST2 show Nfor friend my Nfor
'Nkunku showed my friend to Nfor.'

In the 'unmarked' sentences in (51) and (52), the entire utterance represents information that is all-new. Note that (51) and (52) can be altered if the indirect object is informationally new while the direct object is interpreted as given or contextually salient.

(53) a. Beri ki fo *lá* **wán** Lamnso
Beri PST1 give who child
'Who did Buri give the child to?
b. wu ki fo **wán** *i baá wom* (#**wán**)
3SG PST1 give child PREP father POSS.1SG child
'She gave the child to MY FATHER.'

(54) a. Nkunku à mū dùŋshī *ndā* **ŋkār jà** Limbum
Nkunku PST PST2 show who friend my
'Who did Nkunku show **my friend** to?
b. Nkunku à mū dùŋshī **ŋkār jò** *ne Nfor* (#**ŋkār jò**)
Nkunku PST PST2 show friend your PREP Nfor friend your
'Nkunku showed NFOR to my friend.'

The examples in (53) and (54) show that information structure interacts with word order in these languages. More precisely, the direct object can precede the indirect object if the former represents old information in the previous discourse whereas the latter is interpreted as new. Based on the unmarked order in (51)–(52) and their marked counterparts in (53)–(54), one is led to suggest that the DO.IO order in the latter case is derived by focus movement of the DO across the IO. It is important to note that in a context where the direct object is new and the indirect object is given, we end up with a structure that matches the canonical SV.IO.DO order provided in (51) and (52). Let us consider Lamnso (55) and Limbum (56).

(55) a. Beri ki fo **wán** *ka* Lamnso
Beri PST1 give child what
'What did Beri give to the child?
b. Beri ki fo **wun /wán** *ŋwa'* (#**i wun** / **wán**)
Beri PST1 give 3SG child book PREP 3SG child
'Beri gave him/the child a BOOK.'

(56) a. Nkunku à mū dùŋshī **Nfor** *kɛ̄:* Limbum
Nkunku PST PST2 show Nfor what
'What did Nkunku show to Nfor?
b. é / Nkunku à mū dùŋshī **jɛ̄ / Nfor** *rkar* (#ne **jɛ̄ / Nfor**)
3SG Nkunku PST PST2 show 3SG Nfor car PREP 3SG Nfor
'He/Nkunku showed him/Nfor a CAR.'

The order in which the direct object interpreted as new information precedes the indirect object interpreted as given is infelicitous. This suggests that object placement is determined by the information structural properties of the objects. Taking into account the patterns in (51)–(56), it is diffult to think of 'in-situ' focalisation because even in cases wherere the focalised constituents seem not to have moved, focus movement is simply obscured by the unmarked order. The following examples show that postverbal focus marking with a copula can display various ordering patterns in double object and dative-shift constructions. Each ordering is determined by the information structural properties of the objects.

(57) a. Bih ki fo *awuni* [**kingom** wuna **kibán**] a Lamnso
Bih PST1 give children banana and fufu QM
'Did Bih give the children a banana and fufu?'
b. āјà. wu ki fo *awuni/woni* **a dzə kibán**
no 3SG PST1 give 3PL children EXPL be fufu
'No. He gave them the FUFU (not the fufu and a banana).'

(58) a. Nkeni à mū dùŋshī [**Mbɔ̀ŋ** á **Malah**] *ndāp* **ā** Limbum
Nkeni PST PST2 show Mbong and Malah car QM
'Did Nkeni show Mbong and Malah a house?'
b. àjì'. Nkeni à mū dùŋshī **bá Mbɔ̀ŋ** *ndāp*
no Nkeni PST PST2 show be Mbong house
'No. He/Nkeni showed it to MBONG (not to both).'

In (57) and (58) where the two objects are backgrounded in the question under discussion provided as in the (a)'s examples, any constituent can be focus marked. Four ordering possibilities are also allowed in this context. To save space, we provide only one ordering possibility for each language, keeping in mind that other orderings are available. In (57b) the direct object *kiban* 'fufu' is focus marked and it follows the indirect object *awuni* 'children'. In (58b), the indirect object *Mbong* is focus marked and precedes the direct object *ndāp* 'house' as in the unmarked order. In Lamnso (59b), the focalised direct object *kiban* 'fufu' precedes the indirect object *awuni* 'children'. In Limbum (60b), the indirect object *Nfor* is focus marked and is preceded by the direct object *rkar* 'car'.

(59) a. Bih ki fo awuni [**kingom** wuna **kibán**] a Lamnso
Bih PST1 give children banana and fufu QM
'Did Bih give the children [the banana and the fufu]?'
b. āјà. wu ki fo **a dzə kibán** i *awuni* / woni
no 3SG PST1 give EXPL be fufu PREP children them
'No. He gave them the FUFU (not the fufu and the banana).'

(60) a. Nkeni à mū dùŋshī *rkar* **nə̀** [**Mbɔ̀ŋ** á **Nfor**] Limbum
Nkeni PST PST2 show car PREP Mbong and Nfor
'Nkeni show a car to Mbong and Nfor.'
b. àjì'. é / Nkeni à mū dùŋshī *rkar* **bá** nə̀ **Nfor**
no 3SG Nkeni PST PST2 show 3SG be PREP Nfor
'No. He/Nkeni showed a car to Nfor (not to the two of them).'

Recall that focus marking with a copula is used exclusively to express contrast. We retain from (51)–(56) that the unmarked SV.IO.DO order can be altered depending on the information structural properties of the objects. The patterns in (57)–(60) reveal that when both objects are given in the discourse and that one is interpreted contrastively, four ordering possibilities are available. Any object may follow or precede the other.

At this juncture, we have explored two instances of low focalisation. Postverbal focalisation without any morphological marking and postverbal focalisation with morphological marking by means of a copula and an expletive pronoun in Lamnso and without an expletive in Limbum. We saw that there is not always a one-to-one relation between the syntactic position of focus and its interpretation. Nevertheless, some generalisations can be made based on the preceding discussion. First of all, postverbal subject and object focalisation without morphological marking can be interpreted either as new or contrastive information depending on the context. Secondly, postverbal focus marking with the copula always induces a contrastive reading. The discussion also revealed that object placement in the two languages interacts with the discourse properties of the objects. Thus, even in configurations where focalised elements seem to be in place, focus movement is assumed though it is obscured by the unmarked order.

5. Cartographic assumptions

We build on cartographic assumptions that there are functional projections dedicated for information-structural categories between the IP and the vP following Belletti (2001, 2004, 2008) and related work. In this study, we show that there is also a functional subject position in the vP periphery. This position is activated only in focus structures with the copula and interacts with low foci and topics. The low subject position hosts a verbal copula and an expletive pronoun at the final stage of the derivation. From the point of view of interpretation, the subject position does not have any interpretative properties of *aboutness* as is the case with the highest subject position (e.g. Cardinaletti 2004, Rizzi 2006, 2015, 2018, Shlonsky & Rizzi 2018). The role of the low subject position in our case is to satisfy a syntactic requirement, namely the subject condition or the EPP in mainstream minimalist analyses (Chomsky 1995). As such, this position differs from the higher subject position which involves a subject-predicate relation between the logical subject and the verbal predicate. When focus, topic and subject are activated in the discourse, their syntax exploit the low IP layer. The functional heads corresponding to these categories are probing positions that initiate search (Chomsky 2000, 2001). These heads attract phrases endowed with corresponding scope-discourse features to their respective specifier positions in order to satisfy the subject, focus and topic criteria (Rizzi 1997, Cardinaletti 2004, Rizzi 2006, Shlonsky & Rizzi 2018). Belletti (2001)'s proposal on Italian and subsequent works such as Aboh (2007) on Aghem (Grassfields Bantu), Quarezemin (2009), Armelin (2011), Kato (2013), Lacerda (2016), Cépeda & Cyrino (2020) on Brazilian

Portuguese suggest that the functional field above the vP periphery parallels with the clausal left periphery (Rizzi 1997). For instance, Belletti's motivation for clause-internal focus and topic positions is based on the interpretative and intonational properties of postverbal subjects in Italian, the vP left periphery of which is simplified in (61). In compliance with Rizzi (1997), Belletti suggests that the clause-internal focus can be followed or preceded by the topic.

(61) [IP…[TopP…[FocP…[TopP…[vP]]]]]

It is important to note that the existence of a low focus position has been reported in other languages such as Caribbean Spanish (Bosque 1999) and Malayalam (Jayaseelan 2001), though a more elaborate analysis starts from Belletti (2001). As for the low topic positions discussed here, they are taken on the based of previous mention in the discourse. Thus, they differ from sentence topics which enter into a topic–comment relation (Reinhart 1981, Rizzi 1997).

5.1 Deriving postverbal object foci

One puzzling feature that characterises exhaustive postverbal focused constituents is the presence of the copula and an expletive pronoun in these languages. It was shown that any postverbal constituent preceded by the copula is unequivocally interpreted exhaustively. Let us consider subject focalisation in Lamnso (62a) and direct object focalisation in Limbum (62b) for convenience.

(62)	a.	ki	ʒun	**a**	(*ki)	**dzə**	**Beri**	lav	rən		Lamnso
		PST1	buy	PRON	PST1	be	Beri	house	DEM.PROX		
		'BERI (nobody else) bought this house.'									
	b.	Nfor	à	mū	jʉ́shí	(*à	mū)	**bá**	**ŋgwē**		Limbum
		Nfor	PST	PST1	kill	PST	PST1	be	dog		
		'Nfor killed a DOG (nothing else).'									

Putting the Grassfields Bantu paradigms in (62) side by side with their Romance counterparts in (63) is particularly revealing.[7]

[7] Collins & Essizewa (2007) explore a quasi similar construction in verb focusing in Kabiye, a Gur language spoken in Togo. Verb focusing triggers double pronunciation of the verb. The particle *ki/kʊ́* is followed by the non-finite copy of the verb which takes an infinitive form. The latter may occur at the end of the sentence (i). This construction can convey a contrastive reading on the verb (i) or a temporal interpretation (ii). The *ki/kʊ́* particle precedes the focused verb in a way that is akin to verbal copulas in focalisation contexts in Lamnso and Limbum.

i.	ma-*ní-ʊ*	kabiyɛ	**kí**	*ní-ʊ*	ma-a	yɔɔd-ʊ	kʊ
	1SG-understand-IMPF	Kabiye	KI	understand-INF	1SG-NEG	speak-IMPF	it
	'I only understand Kabiye. I don't speak it.'						
ii.	miŋ-*kɔm*-á	**kʊ́**	*kɔm*	yɔ			
	1SG-arrive-PERF	ki	arrive-INF	PRT			
	'I have just arrived.'						

Verb focusing with doubling goes beyond the scope of this paper.

(63)	a.	Juan	compró	**fue**	UN LIBRO		
		Juan	bought.3.SG	was.3SG	a	book	Caribbean Spanish
		'It was a book that Juan bought.'					Sáez 2019 : 191
	b.	La plupart de mes collègues,	**c'est**	des amis.		French	
		most of my colleagues	CE.is	INDEF.PL friends		Roy & Shlonsky 2019: 158	

Two major observations emerge from (62) and (63). First of all, in each case the post-copula constituent is interpreted as focal (Bosque 1999, Sáez 2019, Roy & Shlonsky 2019). Interestingly, Bosque (1999: 23) indicates that in structures akin to the Caribbean Spanish sentence in (63a) the post-copular constituent is always interpreted contrastively as is the case with the Grassfields Bantu patterns at issue. Secondly, unlike in Lamnso (62a), Limbum (62b) and French (63b), the postverbal copula *fue* 'was' in Caribbean Spanish (63a) is inflected for tense (simple past) and agrees in *phi*-features with the focalised direct object *un libro* 'a book'. Contrary to the Caribbean Spanish pattern, the copulas *dzə̀* (62a) and *bá* (62b) in Lamnso and Limbum are invariable. More specifically, they bear no tense specification. In French *est* 'is' (63b) does not agree with the focalised direct object *des amis* 'friends' but bears person and number features (third person singular). Lamnso (62a) and French (63b) are similar in the sense that in both languages the pronominal elements *a* and *ce* respectively accompany the copula. Last but not least, what makes the Lamnso and Limbum constructions particularly interesting is that they look like pseudo-clefts to some extent. However, this view is undermined by two empirical arguments. Though one is tempted to consider (62b) as a case of pseudo-cleft, this is difficult to prove in the subject focalisation example in (62a) where the focalised subject is followed by the direct object. An analysis along the lines of pseudo-clefts would be difficult to hold in the face of the empirical facts in (62a) and (64).

(64)	a.	Beri	ki	fo	**a**	**dzə**	**Bih**	lav	rən	Lamnso
		Beri	PST1	give	PRON	be	Bih	house	DEM.PROX	
		'Beri gave BIH (nobody else) this house.'								
	b.	Nfor	à	mū	dùŋshī	**bá**	**Nkeni**	ŋgwē		Limbum
		Nfor	PST	PST1	show	be	Nkeni	dog		
		'Nfor showed NKENI (nobody else) a dog.'								

In (64) the focalised indirect object *Bih* is followed by the direct object *lav rən* 'this house'. Lamnso and Limbum also have copular clauses and specificational pseudo-clefts constructions in the sense of Akmajian (1970). The specificational pseudo-clefts and copular clauses in these languages are different from the focus constructions in (64). Some examples of pseudo-clefts and copular clauses are given in (65)–(66) for Lamnso and (67)–(68) for Limbum respectively.

(65)	a.	Who was the person that you saw?								
	b.	wir	w-o	m	ki	jen-in	ki	*dzə*	**ŋkar**	**ʒem**	Lamnso
		person	AGR-REL	I	PST	see-PRT	PST	be	friend	POSS.1SG	
		'The person that I saw was MY FRIEND.'								

(66) a. Who is Bih?

b. Bih *dzə* **wir** **w-o** **m** **kɔŋ-ín** Lamnso

Bih be.PRS person AGR-REL I love.PRS-PRT

'Bih is THE PERSON I LOVE.'

(67) a. What is the thing that you bought?

b. jū: tʃé mɛ m̀ jú à m̀ *bā* **ndāp** Limbum

thing REL 1SG PST3 buy PST PST3 be house

'The thing that I bought was a HOUSE.'

(68) a. Who was Nfor?

b. Nfor à mū *bā* **ŋwɛ̀** **tʃé** **mɛ** **à** **mū** **jɛ̄** Limbum

Nfor PST PST2 be person REL I PST PST2 see

'Nfor was THE PERSON I SAW.'

It transpires from (65)–(68) that the pre-copula part of these sentences is presuppositional whereas the post-copula constituent is focused (see also Shlonsky & Rizzi 2018, Roy & Shlonksy 2019 on copular constructions in French, Italian and Hebrew). The constructions in (65)–(68) differ from the focus constructions under investigation as shown in (64), including many other examples already discussed. The pseudo-cleft and copular constructions in (65)–(68) contain relative clauses. These relative clauses are headed by generic nouns (*person* and *thing*). This property is not found in (64) and related constructions. Semantically, the focused constituents in (64) are interpreted only contrastively whereas the postcopular constituents in (65)–(68) are instances of information focus. If the examples in (64) were pseudo-clefts as well, one would expect them to be interpretatively similar to (65) and (68). Secondly, the focalised constituents in (65) would be clause final even if this distribution is possible in monotransitive constructions such as (62b). But still, the sentences in (62) do not contain relative clauses. The grammaticality of (62) and (64) compared to (65)–(68) is an indication that the former are not pseudo-clefts as one might think. The Grassfields Bantu focus constructions with a postverbal copula deviate from Caribbean Spanish in which the post-copula constituent has to be the leftmost element in the sentence. Unlike the Lamnso and Limbum patterns delineated in (62) and (64), it is reported that Caribbean Spanish does not legitimate any other lexical material on the right of the post-copula constituent (Camacho 2006, Sáez 2019). In this paper, we consider the constructions under discussion not as pseudo-clefts, but as a particular instance of low focalisation with focus movement in the vP periphery. This analysis in our sense is likely to account for similar focus constructions in many Grassfields Bantu languages such as Bafut (69a), Shupamem (69b) and many others with analogous morphosyntax.

(69) a. m̀-fɔ̀ w-á à kɨ̀ fiî **á** **à-bərɨ̀** **j-ì** Bafut

1-chief 1-the SM P2 sell FOC 7-throne 7-his

'The chief sold HIS THRONE (and not his drinking horn).' (Tamanji 2009: 184)

b. à fì **na** **mɔn** ndáp Shupamem

ES sell FOC child house

'It is the child who sold the house.' (Nchare 2012: 474)

At first blush, the examples in (69) seem to be instances of in-situ focalisation. But the fact that they are tightly associated with a postverbal copula leads us to postulate that this does not happen randomly. In other words, the presence of verbal copulas in Lamnso and Limbum and the use of focus markers in Bafut and Shupamem (69) seem to be motivated syntactically. This pushes us to assume that copulas, focus markers and the pronoun used in low focalisation contexts are encoded in the syntactic structure of focus. We assume, in line with Belletti (2001) and related work that these constructions exploit the low focus field. As such, the initial move towards the derivation of the double object constructions in (64), repeated as (70) for convenience is to merge the indirect and direct object with the lexical verb as indicated in (71).

(70) a. Beri ki fo **a** **dzə** **Bih** lav rən — Lamnso
Beri PST1 give PRON be Bih house DEM.PROX
'Beri gave BIH (nobody else) this house.'
b. Nfor à mū dùŋshī **bá Nkeni** ŋgwē — Limbum
Nfor PST PST1 show be Nkeni dog
'Nfor showed NKENI (not someone else) a dog.'

(71) a. ...[$_{vP}$ [Beri [$_{v}$ fo [$_{VP}$ Bih[$_{V}$ ~~fo~~ [$_{DP}$ lav rən]] — Lamnso
Beri give Bih house this
b. ...[$_{vP}$ [Nfor [$_{v}$ dùŋshī [$_{VP}$ Nkeni [$_{V}$ ~~dùŋshī~~ [$_{DP}$ ŋgwē]] — Limbum
Nfor show Nkeni dog

Suspension marks indicate the missing structure to be filled as the derivation proceeds. Building on Larson's (1988) vP-shell hypothesis, we assume that the lexical verb is initially merged in the lower VP but raises to the outer vP (strikethrough indicates movement), yielding the verb–indirect object–direct object order. By assumption, we consider the verbal copulas *dzə̀* (70a) and *bá* (70b) as grammaticalised focus markers that lexicalise the focus head in the syntax. The grammaticalisation of copulas into focus markers is not new in the literature. It has been reported cross-linguistically in genetically unrelated languages as Maroon Creoles (Migge 2002), Cushitic languages (Frascarelli & Puglielli 2005, Frascarelli 2011), Hausa (Abdoulaye 2006). Copulas are therefore taken as discourse markers introduced under the FOC head. The next step consists in merging the FOC head with the vP and introducing the copula.

(72) a. …[$_{FocP}$ [$_{Foc}$ **dzə̀** [$_{vP}$ [Beri [$_{v}$ fo [$_{VP}$ Bih[$_{V}$ ~~fo~~ [$_{DP}$ lav rən]]] — Lamnso
be Beri give Bih house this
b. …[$_{FocP}$ [$_{Foc}$ **bá** [$_{vP}$ [Nfor [$_{v}$ dùŋshī [$_{VP}$ Nkeni [$_{V}$ ~~dùŋshī~~ [$_{DP}$ ŋgwē]]] — Limbum
be Nfor show Nkeni dog

From now on, we consider that the copulas *dzə̀* and *bá* in (72) are akin to left peripheral focus markers in other languages such as Gungbe (Aboh 2004), Tuki (Biloa 2013), Basaá (Bassong 2014, Bassong, Belletti & Rizzi forthcoming). We also posit that the focus markers *á* and *na* in the Grassfields languages Bafut and Shupamem in (69) would play the same role. Once introduced in the derivation, the FOC head is ready to probe over/search for the constituent targeted for focalisation. Assuming a 'featural Relativized Minimality' (fRM) according to which morphosyntactic features define syntactic positions (Starke 2001, Rizzi 2004b, 2018b), it is legitimate to think that the focalised indirect objects *Bih* (71a) and *Nkeni* (71b) are able to raise to Spec-FocP across the intervening subject since both do not have the same featural make up. Put another way, given that focalised elements are quantificational, they bear an operator feature which allows them to undergo focus movement across an intervening subject. In line with this version of Relativized Minimality, in the calculation of intervention, morphosyntactic features are organised into feature classes such that an element endowed with a given feature cannot be blocked by another endowed with a distinct featural make up. Even if the formation of what we consider here as a low quantificational chain between a focalised indirect object and its tail cannot be blocked by an intervening subject, there remains another puzzle to be solved. This has to do with the presence of the expletive *a* in Lamnso (70a) and its role in the syntactic derivation. One needs to solve this problem in a stepwise fashion. One option is to raise the lexical subject to the highest subject SubjP (Cardinaletti 2004, Rizzi & Shlonsky 2018, Roy & Shlonsky 2019) or TP position and move the indirect object to Spec-FocP as in (73).

(73) a. [$_{TP}$ Beri$_i$ [$_T$ ki [$_{FocP}$ Bih$_j$ [$_{Foc}$ **dzə̀** [$_{vP}$ [t$_i$ [$_v$ fo [$_{VP}$ t$_j$ [$_V$ ~~fo~~ [$_{DP}$ lav rən]]]]
Beri PST1 Bih be give house this
b. [$_{TP}$ Nfor$_i$ [$_T$ à mū [$_{FocP}$ Nkeni$_j$ [$_{Foc}$ **bá** [$_{vP}$ [t$_i$ [$_v$ dùŋshī [$_{VP}$ t$_j$ [$_V$ ~~dùŋshī~~ [$_{DP}$ ŋgwē]]]]
Nfor PSTPST2 Nkeni be show dog

Once the lexical subject is probed over by the T head, it raises to Spec-TP to satisfy the subject-criterion (Rizzi 2005). The movement of the indirect object to the low Spec-FocP takes place. However, three problems still remain, namely the position of the expletive *a* on the left of the copula in Lamnso, the final positions of the copula and the the verb. More precisely, how does the lexical verb happen to precede the pronoun *a* and the copula *dzə̀* as observed in Lamnso (70a), and how does it happen to precede the copula *bá* in Limbum (70b)? To answer these questions, we build on the cartography of subject positions. We consider that there exist distinct subject positions in the clausal spine. Each position is associated with specific properties in the clause (e.g. Shlonsky 2000, Cardinaletti 2004, Shlonsky & Rizzi 2018, Roy & Shlonsky 2019). The presence of the copula and the pronoun in postverbal focus focalisation provides empirical evidence that seem to license a dedicated focus and subject positions in the low IP field in these languages. In order to account for the position of the pronominal element *a* in Lamnso (70a), let us assume along the lines of Roy & Shlonsky (2019) that this pronoun plays the same role as the French pronominal expletive *ce* in the copula clause in (63a). However, contrary to French where Spec-SubjP the position occupied by the pronominal *ce* is reported to be higher than TP, we suggest that there is a low subject phrase (SubjP) in the vP periphey.[8] Spec-SubjP hosts the expletive *a* in Lamnso and a null *pro* in Limbum. This SubjP is lower than TP and belongs to the functional sequence between the position dedicated to the Asp(ect)P and the vP. More precisely, the low SubjP is sandwiched between the AspP and the low FocP. Suppose that in configurations such as (74), two kinds of elements can appear to form two distinct derivational chains, namely a head and a phrasal chain. Heads are represented by circles and maximal projections are represented by rectangles. Descriptively, a relation between the head of a chain and its tail is disrupted if there is an intervening head. As such, the following holds for head and phrasal movement.

[8] In their analysis of copular *ce*-constructions, Roy & Shlonsky (2019) distinguish between two subject positions in French, namely Subj1 and Subj2. When both are activated in the same clause, SubjP2 is higher than SubjP1. The former, occupied by the lexical subject fulfils the aboutness properties while the latter, occupied by the expletive *ce* fulfils the EPP and *phi*-requirements on the Subj1 head.

(74) a. *X Y t_X

b. *$\boxed{XP}$ $\boxed{YP}$ $\boxed{t_{XP}}$

This is shown in (75a) for Lamnso and (75b) in Limbum.

(75) a. [$_{TP}$ $\boxed{\text{Beri}}$[$_T$ ki[$_{AspP}$ [$_{Asp}$ fo[$_{SubjP}$ $\boxed{\text{a}}$[$_{Subj}$ t_{fo} [$_{FocP}$ Bih[$_{Foc}$ **dzə̀** [$_{vP}$[$\boxed{t_{Beri}}$[$_v$ t_{fo} [$_{VP}$ t_{Bih}[$_V$ ~~fo~~
Beri PST1 give EXPL Bih be
[$_{DP}$ lav rən]]]]]]
house DEM.PROX

b. [$_{TP}$ $\boxed{\text{Nfor}}$ [$_T$ à mū[$_{AspP}$[$_{Asp}$ dùŋshī [$_{SubjP}$ $\boxed{pro}$[$_{Subj}$ $t_{dùŋshī}$[$_{FocP}$ Nkeni[$_{Foc}$ **bá** [$_{vP}$[$\boxed{t_{Nfor}}$ [$_v$ $t_{dùŋshī}$
Nfor PST PST2 show Nkeni be
[$_{VP}$ t_{Nkeni} [$_V$ ~~dùŋshī~~ [$_{DP}$ ŋgwē]]]]]]
dog

The derivations in (75) are problematic in two ways. First of all, v-to-Asp movement is illegitimate because it skips the FOC head occupied by the verbal copulas *dzə̀* in (75a) and *bá* in (75b), in violation of Relativized Minimality (Rizzi 1990, 2004). Subject extraction from Spec-vP to Spec-TP is also problematic because the displaced subject crosses over the intermediate Spec-SubjP position occupied by the expletive *a* in Lamnso (75a). By assumption, we consider that Spec-SubjP is filled by a null *pro* in Limbum (75b). In other words, the expletive *a* in Lamnso (75a) and its silent counterpart in Limbum block the formation of an A-chain between the subjects in Spec-TP and the silent copies left behind in Spec-vP. As a result, subject extraction across an intermediate subject position is blocked. Whatever the case, even if the subject were to move via the intermediate Spec-SubjP in Limbum (75b) under the assumption that that Spec-SubjP is completely empty, such a movement step would still remain problematic because SubjP is a criterial position (Rizzi 2006). In line with the criterial approach to subject positions, moving the lexical subject to the intermediate SubjP in the case of (75b) will lead to freezing effects, precluding the subject from moving further. In order to circumvent these minimality and freezing effects, we build on the interplay between information structure and syntax and the *smuggling* approach (Collins 2005, Belletti & Collins 2020, Shlonsky 2024). (70a) and (70b) are repeated as (76a) and (76b) for convenience. In the (b) answers, we use bold to highlight focused constituents and italics for non focal ones.

(76) a. Beri ki fo [**Chin** wuna **Bih**] *láv vən* Lamnso
Beri PST1 give Chin and Bih house this
'Buri gave Chin and Bih this house.'

b. ājà. Beri ki fo **a** **dzə** **Bih** *láv rən*
no Beri PST1 give PRON be Bih house this
'No. Beri gave BIH (not Chin) this house.'

(77) a. Nfor à mū dùŋshī [**Mbɔŋ** á **Nkeni**] *ŋgwē* Limbum
Nfor PST PST1 show Mbong and Nkeni dog
'Nfor showed Mbong and Nkeni a dog.'
b. Nfor à mū dùŋshī **bá Nkeni** *ŋgwē*
Nfor PST PST1 show be Nkeni dog
'Nfor showed NKENI (not someone else) a dog.'

In (76b), the focalised indirect object *Bih* contrasts with *Chin*. Similarly, in (77b), the focused indirect object *Nkeni* contrasts with *Nkunku*. We assume that the italised constituents *láv rən* 'this house (76b) and *ŋgwē* 'dog' (77b) is clause internal topics in the sense of Frascarelli (2011) in virtue of representing given information in the discourse. Thus, they differ from left peripheral or *aboutness topics* (Reinhart 1981, Rizzi 1997). The topicality of the italicised objects operates not on the basis of *aboutness* but on discourse givenness or familiarity (e.g. Roberts 2003, Frascarelli & Hinterhölzl 2007, Frascarelli & 2011). This also complies with Belletti (2004)'s assumptions about the existence of a low topic position in the vP periphery. In this vein, we adopt the idea that there is a low topic position in the c-command domain of the focus phrase. The derivation will proceed as follows with a temporary V-to-v movement. When vP merges with the Top head, the direct object moves to Spec-TopP to satisfy the topic-criterion (Rizzi 1997). This low topic movement is taken as a type of movement in a scope-taking position. Thus, it cannot be blocked by the intervening subject and indirect object.

(78) a. ...[$_{TopP}$ lav vən [$_{Top}$ [$_{vP}$ [Beri [$_{v}$ fo [$_{VP}$ Bih[$_{V}$ ~~fo~~ [$_{DP}$ t$_{lav\ rən}$]]] Lamnso
house this Beri give Bih
b. ...[$_{TopP}$ ŋgwē [$_{Top}$ [$_{vP}$ [Nfor [$_{v}$ dùŋshī [$_{VP}$ Nkeni [$_{V}$ ~~dùŋshī~~ [$_{DP}$ t$_{ŋgwē}$]]] Limbum
dog Nfor show Nkeni

The next step consists in merging TopP with the FOC(us) head occupied by the verbal copula, which in our analysis is taken as a focus marker. Once the focus head is activated, it attracts the indirect object to Spec-FocP as indicated in (79a) in Lamnso and (79b) in Limbum.

(79) a. [$_{FocP}$ Bih [$_{Foc}$ **dzə̀** [$_{TopP}$ lav vən [$_{Top}$ [$_{vP}$ [Beri [$_{v}$ fo [$_{VP}$ t$_{Bih}$[$_{V}$ ~~fo~~ [$_{DP}$ t$_{lav\ rən}$]]]]
Bih be house this Beri give
b. [$_{FocP}$ Nkeni [$_{Foc}$ **bá** [$_{TopP}$ ŋgwē [$_{Top}$ [$_{vP}$ [Nfor [$_{v}$ dùŋshī [$_{VP}$ t$_{Nkeni}$ [$_{V}$ ~~dùŋshī~~ [$_{DP}$ t$_{ŋgwē}$]]]]
Nkeni be dog Nfor show

In (79), the focus-criterion is achieved locally in Spec-Head configuration between the focused constituent and the focus marker represented here by the copula in FOC. However, in these languages, the copula always precedes the focalised constituent as in (76) and (77). In order to obtain the copula-XP$_{FOC}$ order, FocP merges with the Subj(ect) head and Spec-SubjP is filled by the expletive *a* in Lamnso (80a) and a null *pro* in Limbum (80b). The copula head raises from Foc to Subj, yielding the surface order expletive-copula-XP$_{FOC}$ as shown in (80).

(80) a. [SubjP *a* [Subj **dzə̀** [FocP Bih [Foc t**dzə̀** [TopP lav vən [Top [vP [Beri [v fo [VP tBih[V ~~fo~~
EXPL be Bih house this Beri give
[DP tlav rən]]]]]

b. [SubjP *pro* [Subj **bá** [FocP Nkeni [Foc t**bá** [TopP ŋgwē [Top[vP [Nfor [v dùŋshī [VP tNkeni
be Nkeni dog Nfor show
[V ~~dùŋshī~~ [DP tŋgwē]]]]]

Being a verbal element, we assume that the copula is attracted by a strong verbal and EPP feature in Subj to satisfy the EPP and abstract agreement requirements in a Spec-Head configuration with the expletive *a* in Lamnso and a *pro* in Limbum. The difference between the two languages and the Carribean Portuguese and French patterns in (63) relies on the fact that in Romance, the copula can be inflected for tense and *phi*-agreement unlike in Lamnso and Lamnso where the copula is always in the present form by default and lacks *phi*-agreement specification.[9] The focalised indirect object in Spec-FocP cannot raise further in Spec-SubjP to satisfy such requirements. In fact, once the indirect direct is moved to Spec-FocP, it gets frozen in place and becomes blind to further search. Two issues remain to be addressed in (80), namely the final position of the logical subject and the verb. How do we end up having the lexical subject in its canonical position in cases like (76b) and (77b)? How does the lexical verb happen to linearly precede the expletive pronoun, the copula and the focalised direct object? As shown in (81), subject movement to the higher subject position across the low SubjP violates Relativized Minimality (Rizzi 1990). Subject extraction is therefore blocked. Even if the subject were to raise temporarily to SubjP in Limbum (81b) due to the absence of an overt expletive in Spec-SubjP, this would still freeze the subject as a consequence of criterial freezing (Rizzi 2006).

(81) a. * Beri ...[SubjP *a* [Subj **dzə̀** [FocP Bih [Foc t**dzə̀** [TopP lav vən [Top[vP [tBeri [v fo [VP tBih
Beri EXPL be Bih house this give
[V ~~fo~~ [DP tlav rən]]]]]

b. *Nfor..[SubjP *pro* [Subj **bá** [FocP Nkeni [Foc t**bá** [TopP ŋgwē [Top[vP [tNfor [v dùŋshī [VP tNkeni
be Nkeni dog show
[V ~~dùŋshī~~ [DP tŋgwē]]]]]

As for the final position of the lexical verb, we saw in Section 3.1.2 that there is semantic and morphosyntatic evidence in support of verb movement in both languages. In the configuration in (82), the verb cannot raise pass the intermediate heads as this would induce a violation of the Head Movement Constraint (Travis 1984).

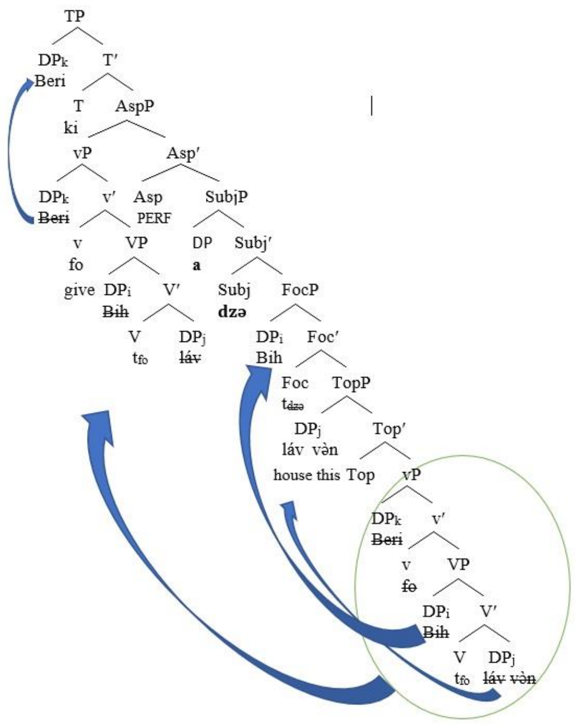
[9] One may speculate about the existence of a tense projection in the vicinity of the copula in low focalisation in Grassfields Bantu, building on the morphosyntactic properties of the copula in Romance (63). Recall that the structures in (63) are copular constructions, the structure of which contains a tense projection(cf. Roy & Shlonsky 2019). As noted earlier, these Romance copular clauses differ from the focus constructions discussed here. The possibility of having a low tense projection around the copula in low focalisation in addition to the tense projection associated with the lexical verb like in (76)–(77) is an interesting topic that will be explored across Grassfields Bantu in future research.

(82) a. *fo ...[$_{\text{SubjP}}$ *a* [$_{\text{Subj}}$ **dzə̀** [$_{\text{FocP}}$ Bih [$_{\text{Foc}}$ t$_{\textbf{dzə̀}}$ [$_{\text{TopP}}$ lav vən [$_{\text{Top}}$ [$_{\text{vP}}$ [Beri [$_{\text{v}}$ t$_{\text{fo}}$ [$_{\text{VP}}$ t$_{\text{Bih}}$
give EXPL be Bih house this Beri
[$_{\text{V}}$ ~~fo~~ [$_{\text{DP}}$ t$_{\text{lav rən}}$]]]]]

b. *dùŋshī ...[$_{\text{SubjP}}$ *pro* [$_{\text{Subj}}$ **bá** [$_{\text{FocP}}$ Nkeni [$_{\text{Foc}}$ t$_{\textbf{bá}}$ [$_{\text{TopP}}$ ŋgwē [$_{\text{Top}}$[$_{\text{vP}}$ [Nfor [$_{\text{v}}$ t$_{\text{dùŋshī}}$ [$_{\text{VP}}$ t$_{\text{Nkeni}}$
be Nkeni dog Nfor show
[$_{\text{V}}$ ~~dùŋshī~~ [$_{\text{DP}}$ t$_{\text{ŋgwē}}$]]]]]

It follows from (81) and (82) that subject and verb extraction are blocked by minimality effects. The only elements that remain inside the vP after topic and focus movement of the objects are the verb, the subject and the silent copies of the extracted objects. Keeping with the idea that the lexical verb raises out of the vP, the derivation in (80) proceeds by introducing aspectual and temporal information in the derivation. This opens up the possibility to raise the verb and the subject in a way that helps to eschew minimality effects. In (76) and (77), only tense is expressed morphologically. We assume that aspectual information is present in the syntax, but covertly expressed at PF. In the tree in (83), when Asp(ect) is introduced in the derivation, this is followed by the *Smuggling* (Collins 2005) of the remnant vP to Spec-AspP. The merging of AspP with the T head is followed by subextraction of the lexical subject out of the moved vP to Spec-TP for the satisfaction of the aboutness properties. Lamnso is used for illustration in (83), keeping with the idea that the same analysis applies for Limbum.

(83)



In line with the criterial approach adopted in cartographic syntax, criterial heads are halting positions that induce freezing effects on the phrases moved in their specifier positions. Unlike Subj, Asp is not criterial. Thus, remnant vP movement in Spec-AspP does not induce freezing effects on the vP. Subextraction of the subject is therefore legitimate as long as it applies in a non-criterial position. Subject subextraction in this case does not violate the freezing principle in the spirit of criterial freezing in cartographic syntax. As for *Smuggling* (Collins 2005, Belletti & Collins 2020, Shlonsky 2024), it helps to circumvent minimality and freezing effects that would arise if the lexical subject and the verb were to move in isolation. By moving the remnant vP, the lexical verb succeeds to avoid minimality effects and to reach the inflectional domain where it can value its aspectual features (Aboh & Dyakonova 2009, Pollock (1989). Smuggling also helps the subject to escape minimality and freezing effects and to reach the higher subject position for the satisfaction of the subject-criterion and its aboutness properties.

The discussion on the distribution of postverbal objects in section 3.2.2 revealed that there are also constructions in which a focalised direct object in clause final position can be preceded by the indirect object. In our analysis, we posit that in such contexts the indirect object functions as a clause internal topic, using previous mention in the discourse as a property of topichood.

(84) a. Bih ki fo awuni **vingom** a — Lamnso
Bih PST1 give children bananas QM
'Did Bih give the children bananas?'

b. ājà. wu ki fo *awuni / woni* **a dzə̀ kibán**
no 3SG PST1 give children 3PL EXPL be fufu
'No. He gave them/the children the FUFU (not the bananas).'

(85) a. Mbɔŋ là: ínɛ̄ Nkeni à mū dùŋshī Nfor **rkār** — Limbum
Mbong say.PRS that Nkeni PST PST2 show Nfor car
'Mbong says that Nkeni showed Nfor a car.'

b. é Nkeni à mū dùŋshī *Nfor* / *jɛ̄* **bá ndāp**
3SG Nkeni PST PST2 show Nfor 3SG be house
'He/Nkeni showed Nfor/ him a HOUSE (not a car).'

Drawing on (83), we suggest that (84b) and (85b) exploit the vP left periphery. We consider the Limbum example in (84b) for illustration, keeping in mind that Lamnso delineates the same syntactic structure. The derivation proceeds as follows. In (86a), the vP made of its internal and external arguments merges with the focus head occupied by the copula *bá*. The direct object *ndāp* 'house' is attracted to Spec-FocP in a Spec-Head relation with the copula. The lexical verb raises temporarily to the little v head. In (86b), FocP merges with the Subj head followed by head raising of the copula from Foc to Subj. A null expletive, a counterpart of the expletive *a* in Lamnso lexicalises Spec-SubjP to satisfy the EPP.

(86) a. ...$[_{\text{FocP}}$ ndāp $[_{\text{Foc}}$ **bá** $[_{\text{vP}}$ [Nkeni $[_{\text{v}}$ dùŋshī $[_{\text{VP}}$Nfor $[_{\text{V}}$ ~~dùŋshī~~ $[_{\text{DP}}$ ~~ndāp~~]]]
house be Nkeni show Nfor

b. ...$[_{\text{SubjP}}$ *pro*$[_{\text{Subj}}$ **bá** $[_{\text{FocP}}$ ndāp$[_{\text{Foc}}$ $t_{bá}$ $[_{\text{vP}}$ [Nkeni $[_{\text{v}}$ dùŋshī $[_{\text{VP}}$Nfor $[_{\text{V}}$ ~~dùŋshī~~ $[_{\text{DP}}$ ~~ndāp~~]]]]
be house Nkeni show Nfor

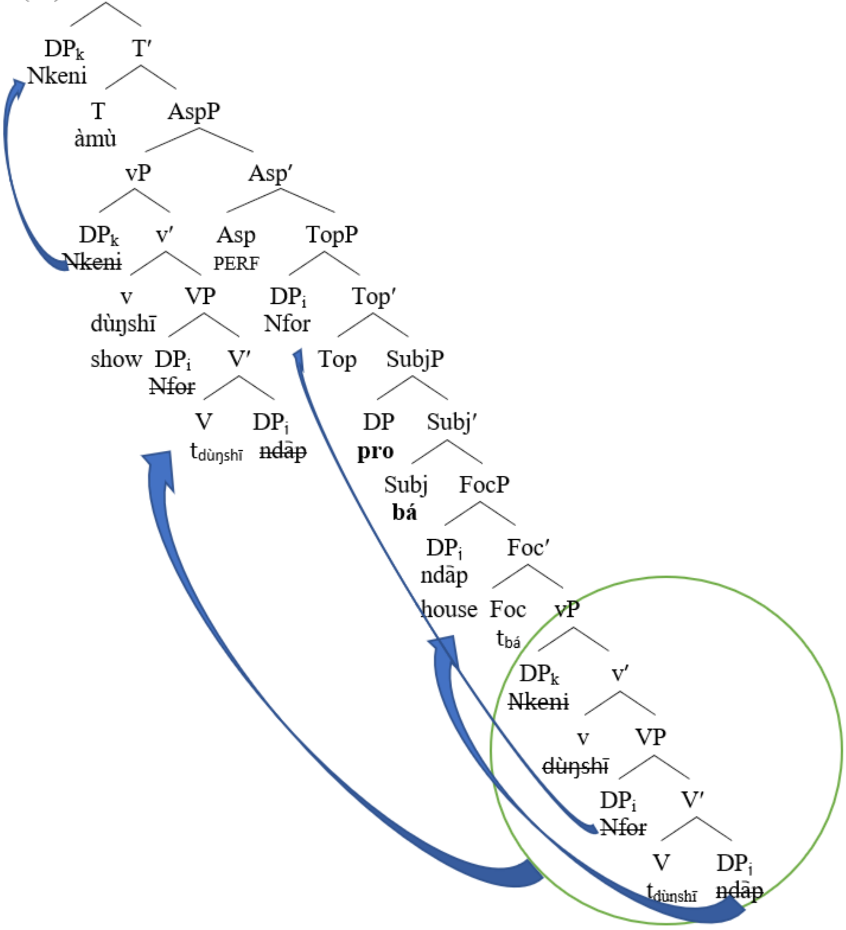
As suggested earlier, we assume that Foc-to-Subj movement of the copula is triggered by a strong verbal feature hosted in Subj. This movement leads to the satisfaction of the EPP and yields a configuration in which the focalised direct *ndāp* 'house' object is preceded by the copula. In (87), the structure obtained in (86b) merges with a null TOP(ic) head which attracts the indirect object *Nfor* to Spec-TopP. Following Starke (2001), Rizzi (2004), Haegeman (2012), topic movement of the indirect object across the focused direct object does not induce minimality effects as topic and focus are not endowed wih the same featural make up.

As shown in (87), neither the lexical verb *dùŋshī* 'show' nor the subject *Nkeni* can move in isolation. The verb cannot move pass the focus and subject heads. The lexical subject *Nkeni* cannot move across the intermediate Spec-SubjP hosting the null *pro*, nor can it transit over there because Spec-SubjP is a criterial position.

(87) *$_{\text{TP}}$ $\boxed{\text{Nkeni}}$ ...dùŋshī ...[$_{\text{TopP}}$ Nfor [$_{\text{Top}}$ [$_{\text{SubjP}}$ $\boxed{\textit{pro}}$[$_{\text{Subj}}$ **bá** [$_{\text{FocP}}$ ndāp[$_{\text{Foc}}$ t$_{\textbf{bá}}$ [$_{\text{vP}}$ [$\boxed{\text{t}_{\text{Nkeni}}}$ [$_{\text{v}}$ t$_{\text{dùŋshī}}$
Nkeni show Nfor be house
[$_{\text{VP}}$ ~~Nfor~~ [$_{\text{V}}$ ~~dùŋshī~~ [$_{\text{DP}}$ ~~ndāp~~]]]]

Like in (83), in order to circumvent freezing and minimality effects, the remnant vP containing the subject and verb has to move to Spec-AspP across the different interveners. As the Asp(ect) position is not criterial, remnant vP movement to Spec-AspP is followed by subextraction of the subject out of the moved vP for the satisfaction of the subject-criterion (Rizzi 2006) in Spec-TP as shown in (88).

(88)



In our sense, the pre-copula expletive *a* in Lamnso and its null *pro* counterpart in Limbum are externally merged in the low SubjP. This has theoretical implications. The expletive blocks subject movement to Spec-TP when a non-subject constituent is focused postverbally. Secondly, the expletive pronoun contributes to the satisfaction of the subject-condition. The low Spec-SubjP occupied by the expletive in our analysis is not associated with the *aboutness* property (Cardinaletti 2004, Rizzi 2005, 2006, Rizzi & Shlonsky 2018). Only the higher subject, Spec-TP occupied by the lexical subject enters into a subject–predicate relation with the verb in object focalisation with copula marking. The syntactic function of the expletive *a* in Lamnso and the null *pro* in Limbum in Spec-SubjP is confined to the satisfaction of the EPP or subject requirements whereas the copulas convey the discourse function of focus. This is also supported structurally. The low SubjP is lower than the lexical verb whose semantic function is to describe the event and whose role in the syntax is to value the aspect/tense features. From the point of view of semantic interpretation, only the lexical subject in Spec-TP fulfils the aboutness properties at the interface with sound and meaning. Despite this observed disparity between the two subject positions, what remains constant cross-linguistically is the existence of distinct subject sites in the clause. In languages like Hebrew, Italian (Shlonsky &

Rizzi 2018) and French (Roy & Shlonsky 2019), the two subject positions are reported to occur in the high IP field immediately below the complementizer area. Our study reveals that the structural positions of subjects within the clause is a matter of parametric variation and depends on their syntactic function and interpretative properties.

5.2 Deriving postverbal subject foci

In section 4.1.1 it was observed that postverbal focalisation can correlate with new and contrastive interpretation depending on the strategy used. Like postverbal object focalisation with copula marking, postverbal subject focusing marked with the copula is strictly exhaustive. Conversely, postverbal subject focalisation without any copular marking can be interpreted either as new or contrastive depending on the context. We use the Lamnso example in (89) to illustrate subject focus marking with a copula and the Limbum one in (90b) to derive subject focus marking without the copula.

(89) a. **Buri** ki fo Chin àlábá a
Buri PST1 give Chin shoes QM
'Did Buri give Chin the shoes?'
b. ājà. ki fo **a dzə̀ Bih** Chin àlábá
no PST1 give PRON be Bih Chin shoes
'No, BIH (not Buri) gave Chin the shoes.'

(90) a. à mū dùŋshī **ndā** Nkunku ŋgwē
PST PST2 show who Nkunku dog
'Who showed Nkunku a dog?'
b. à mū dùŋshī **Nfor** Nkunku ŋgwē
PST PST2 show Nfor Nkunku dog
'NFOR showed Nkunku to me.'

Unlike in the Grassfields Bantu languages Aghem (2a) and Shupamem (4a) where the canonical subject position is filled by an overt expletive in verb–subject reversal, no overt expletive fills the subject position in similar contexts in Lamnso and Limbum. We assume that in subject reversal structures such as (89b) and (90b), the canonical subject position is filled by a non-referential *pro* which forms a representational chain with the reversed subject in the low FocP. As stated earlier, since the constructions in (89b) and (90b) are not pseudo-clefts, we consider that the constituents following the post-verbal subject are clause internal topics based on discourse givenness. Taking into account the micro-discourse provided for each case, the objects are assumed to function as clause internal topics. In Lamnso (89b), the subject is contrastively interpreted whereas in Limbum (90b) the focused subject is informational. Let us assume at the moment that in (89b) and (90b) the topicalised objects do not move at all because nothing constrains them to. The derivation of (89b) and (90b) is obtained as follows. The vP merges with the FOC head lexicalised by the copula *dzə̀* in Lamnso (91a). The Foc head is silent in Limbum (91b). The verb moves to v while the focalised subject is attracted to Spec-FocP.

(91) a. ...[$_{\text{FocP}}$ Bih$_i$ [$_{\text{Foc}}$ **dzə̀** [$_{\text{vP}}$ [~~Bih~~$_i$ [$_{\text{v}}$ fo [$_{\text{VP}}$ Chin [$_{\text{V}}$ ~~fo~~ [$_{\text{DP}}$ àlábá]]
Bih be give Chin shoes
b. ...[$_{\text{FocP}}$ Nfor$_i$ [$_{\text{Foc}}$ [$_{\text{vP}}$ [~~Nfor~~$_i$ [$_{\text{v}}$ dùŋshī [$_{\text{VP}}$ Nkeni [$_{\text{V}}$ ~~dùŋshī~~ [$_{\text{DP}}$ ŋgwē]]
Nfor show Nkeni dog

FocP merges with Subj in Lamnso (92a), followed by Foc-to-Subj movement of the copula for the satisfaction of the EPP with the expletive *a* in Spec-SubjP. In Limbum (92b) nothing motivates the activation of a Subj head. The activation of Subj is dependent on the presence of the copula. At this stage, one has to determine how verb–subject reversal in Lamnso (89b) and Limbum (90b) is derived. This problem is solved in two different ways. In Lamnso (92a), the verb cannot get to the Asp(ect) head by crossing the intermediate Foc and Subj heads. In Limbum (92b), Subj is not activated and the FOC(us) head is empty. So V-to-Asp movement via the FOC head is allowed in Limbum (92b).

(92) a.*..fo..[$_{\text{SubjP}}$ **a**$_i$ [$_{\text{Subj}}$ **dzə̀**[$_{\text{FocP}}$ Bih$_i$ [$_{\text{Foc}}$ t$_{\text{dzə̀}}$ [$_{\text{vP}}$ [~~Bih~~ [$_{\text{v}}$ t$_{\text{fo}}$ [$_{\text{VP}}$ Chin [$_{\text{V}}$ ~~fo~~ [$_{\text{DP}}$ àlábá]]]]
give EXPL be Bih Chin shoes

b. [$_{\text{Asp}}$ dùŋshī [$_{\text{FocP}}$ Nfor$_i$ [$_{\text{Foc}}$ t$_{\text{dùŋshī}}$ [$_{\text{vP}}$ [~~Nfor~~ [$_{\text{v}}$ t$_{\text{dùŋshī}}$ [$_{\text{VP}}$ Nkeni [$_{\text{V}}$ t$_{\text{dùŋshī}}$ [$_{\text{DP}}$ ŋgwē]]]]
show Nfor Nkeni dog

Verb–subject reversal in Limbum (92b) is obtained by merging FocP with a null Asp(ect) head followed by successive cyclic verb raising to Asp via the Foc head. The final derivation of (90b) in Limbum consists in the merging of the T head with AspP followed by the external merge of a null *pro* in Spec-TP as illustrated in (93).

(93) [$_{\text{TP}}$ *pro* [$_{\text{T}}$ àmū [$_{\text{AspP}}$[$_{\text{Asp}}$ dùŋshī [$_{\text{FocP}}$ Nfor$_i$ [$_{\text{Foc}}$ t$_{\text{dùŋshī}}$ [$_{\text{vP}}$ ~~Nfor~~$_i$ [$_{\text{v}}$ t$_{\text{dùŋshī}}$ [$_{\text{VP}}$ Nkeni [$_{\text{V}}$ ~~dùŋshī~~
show Nfor Nkeni
[$_{\text{DP}}$ ŋgwē]]]]
dog

Coming back to the partial clause structure in Lamnso (92a), and compared to Limbum (92b)–(93), it follows that the activation of Subj is dependent on the presence of the copula. The presence of the copula induces minimality effects on v-to-Asp movement. This does not only hold for subject focalisation in verb–subject reversal (89b). It also occurs in postverbal object focalisation with a verbal copula as in (83) and (88). Like in (83) and (88), the minimality effects induced by the intervening heads in the Lamnso example in (92) can be avoided by *Smuggling*. The implementation of *Smuggling* in the double object construction in Lamnso (92), repeated as (94) for convenience consists in evacuating the vP of its arguments so that the remnant vP contains only the lexical verb and the silent copies of the extracted arguments.

(94) ...[$_{\text{SubjP}}$ **a** [$_{\text{Subj}}$ **dzə̀** [$_{\text{FocP}}$ Bih$_i$ [$_{\text{Foc}}$ t$_{\text{dzə̀}}$ [$_{\text{vP}}$ [~~Bih~~ [$_{\text{v}}$ fo [$_{\text{VP}}$ Chin [$_{\text{V}}$ ~~fo~~ [$_{\text{DP}}$ àlábá]]]]
EXPL be Bih give Chin shoes

In comparison with the Limbum structures in (92b) and (93) where the internal arguments remain unmoved, in (94), not only the focused subject, but also the objects have to move out of the vP. We keep with the assumption that in contexts such as (89b) and (90b) the internal arguments function as clause internal topics. Thus, the derivation in (94) should be revised as follows. In (95), vP is merged with the first Top head. The lexical verb *fo* 'give' temporarily moves to the little v head. Based on the pragmatic conditions licensing these constructions, when the subject is focused, the internal arguments are backgrounded. Using previous mention as a licensing condition for topicality, we posit that the entire lower VP containing the internal arguments *Chin* and *àlábá* 'shoes' forms a topic chunk. Thus, V-to-v movement of the verb is followed by topic movement of the VP chunk to Spec-TopP. Topic movement of the lower VP across the lexical subject in Spec-vP is legitimate under the assumption that the moved VP and the subject DP in Spec-vP do not have the same featural make up. VP is endowed with verbal features while the subject DP is nominal, in line with featural relativized minimality. Thus, the lexical subject in Spec-vP cannot induce minimality effects on topic movement.

(95) ...[$_{\text{TopP}}$ [$_{\text{VP}}$ Chin [$_{\text{V}}$ ~~fo~~ [$_{\text{DP}}$ àlábá] [$_{\text{Top}}$ [$_{\text{vP}}$ [Bih [$_{\text{v}}$ fo ~~[VP Chin [V fo [DP àlábá]~~]]]
Chin shoes Bih give

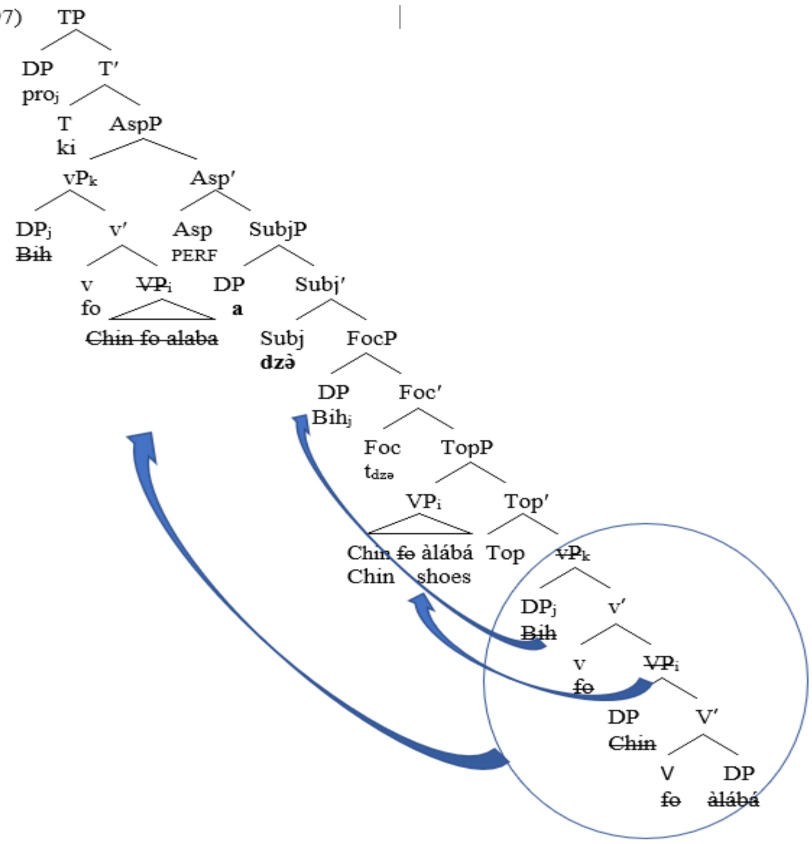
The merging of TopP with the focus head is followed by focus movement of the subject in Spec-FocP (96a). Based on featural Relativized Minimality, focus movement across a topic does not induce any minimality effects. Focus movement is followed by the merging of FocP with the Subj head followed by Foc-to-Subj movement of the copula (96b).

(96) a. [$_{\text{FocP}}$ Bih$_{\text{j}}$ [$_{\text{Foc}}$ **dzə̀** [$_{\text{TopP}}$ [$_{\text{VP}}$ Chin [$_{\text{V}}$ ~~fo~~ [$_{\text{DP}}$ àlábá][$_{\text{vP}}$ ~~Bih~~$_{\text{j}}$[$_{\text{v}}$ fo ~~[VP Chin [V fo~~
Bih be Chin shoes give
~~[DP àlábá]~~]]]]

b. [$_{\text{SubjP}}$ **a** [$_{\text{Subj}}$ **dzə̀** [$_{\text{FocP}}$ Bih$_{\text{j}}$ [$_{\text{Foc}}$ t$_{\textbf{dzə̀}}$ [$_{\text{TopP}}$ [$_{\text{VP}}$ Chin [$_{\text{V}}$ ~~fo~~ [$_{\text{DP}}$ àlábá][$_{\text{vP}}$ ~~Bih~~$_{\text{j}}$ [$_{\text{v}}$ fo
EXPL be Bih Chin shoes give
~~[VP Chin [V fo [DP àlábá]~~]]]]]

In (96b), the expletive *a* is externally merged in Spec-SubjP in a Spec-Head relation with the moved copula. As shown in (96b), after vP evacuation the remnant vP contains the lexical verb *fo* 'give' as the only pronounced element. The next step consists in moving the remnant vP to Spec-AspP. AspP is merged with the T head and a null expletive *pro* is inserted in Spec-TP as depicted in (97).

(97)



6 Conclusion

In this paper, evidence from Grassfields Bantu languages were provided in support of the hypothesis that there are dedicated subject, focus and topic positions in the functional sequence connecting the inflectional domain (IP) to the thematic area (vP). Drawing on previous literature on the functional spine between IP and vP, we provided additional evidence based on the use of verbal copulas and the interpretative properties of postverbal subjects and objects in focalisation that the vP periphery in Lamnso and Limbum is an articulate field made of distinct functional projections. We discussed two instances of postverbal focalisation. The first one dealed with subject and object focusing by which a verbal copula and an expletive pronoun in Lamnso and a copula without any overt expletive in Limbum linearly precede the focused constituent. The discourse function of this focus strategy is that of contrastive/corrective identification. From the point of view of syntax, when activated in the discourse the copula lexicalises a focus head while the expletive lexicalises the subject position that immediately c-commands the focus position. This focus strategy involves a complex syntactic configuration as the copula and the expletive induce minimality and freezing effects on verb and subject extraction. Building on the assumption that verbal copulas are grammaticalised focus markers that lexicalise a focus head in the syntax and that the expletive occupies the specifier position of a low subject position above the FocP, we showed that minimality and freezing effects created by the copula and the expletive are circumvented by vP evacuation and the smuggling of the remnant vP to Spec-AspP across the interveners. From the Spec-AspP position and in the context of object focalisation, the verb can value its aspect(ual) features while the logical subject can subsequently be subextracted from the moved vP to satisfy the subject condition. In subject focalisation with the copula, vP evacuation targets all the arguments to the extent that the vP remnant moved to Spec-AspP contains only the lexical verb and the silent copies of previously extracted arguments. The surface order in which the expletive and the copula always precede the focalised constituent is a result of Foc-to-Subj movement of the copula. The second focus strategy involves verb–subject reversal in subject focalisation and apparently 'in-situ' object foci in SVO sequences. This can correlate with information and contrastive focalisation depending on the context. Syntactically, constructions of this type are derived by a simple focus movement of the subject/object to the low focus field. *Citeris paribus*, both types of focalisation interact with low topic movement in the vP periphery, support a rethinking of the vP from a Bantu perspective and enrich the empirical coverage of the discourse-syntax interplay.

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